# Toward a Dated Humanism

*Can, Wig, Key, Pass in Wong Kar-wai's* Chungking Express

A doctoral thesis




BEST BEFORE
01 MAY 1994

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5 October 2026



The can



The wig



The key



The pass

# Abstract

This thesis advances a new interpretation of Wong Kar-wai's *Chungking Express* (重慶森林, 1994) as the most rigorous cinematic articulation of what I term **dated humanism**: a conception of the human grounded not in permanence — the ten thousand years (萬歲) of sovereign acclamation, the timeless dignity of Renaissance and Enlightenment Man, the cosmic continuity of Confucian *ren* (仁) — but in the human capacity to date, to be dated, and to give dates. Produced in the interval between the Sino-British Joint Declaration (1984) and the transfer of sovereignty (1997), in a polity uniquely possessed of advance knowledge of its own expiry, the film converts Hong Kong's political temporality into an erotics and an ethics of the dated.

Reading the film through four objects — the **can**, the **wig**, the **key**, and the **boarding pass** — each treated as a *datum* in the etymological sense of "a thing given," I argue that *Chungking Express* stages two gendered responses to a world in which time has been canned. The first is a masculine *hermeneutics of the label*, which reads expiry as destiny and administers mourning by instalment. The second is a feminine *poetics of relabelling*, which disguises, trespasses, swaps, and counterfeits in order to give time to another. The film's diptych is constructed *tête-bêche*, its halves crossing at a single snack-bar counter, and it resolves in what I call the **chiasmus of care**: the policeman relinquishes his uniform for the counter, the counter-girl assumes the uniform of flight, and destination itself is surrendered to the other.

The thesis brings the film into sustained dialogue with the philosophers whose problematics it inherits — Bergson, Benjamin, Heidegger, Freud, Kierkegaard, Barthes, Deleuze, de Certeau, Derrida, Arendt — and with feminist thought from Riviere, Beauvoir, Cixous, Irigaray, Mulvey, Rubin, Federici, and Hochschild to Butler, Ahmed, and Berlant. It also restores to Wong scholarship the Chinese-language intellectual and folk traditions that Anglophone criticism has comparatively neglected: Zhuangzi, the *Huangdi Neijing*, Wang Guowei, the boudoir lament (閨怨), the tale of the White Water Maiden (白水素女), the Weaver Girl and the feather robe, Lu Xun, Eileen Chang, Liu Yichang, and Xi Xi. Comparative readings of Varda, Akerman, Demy,

Antonioni, Godard, Tsai Ming-liang, and Ann Hui situate the film within a transnational history of feminist and humanist cinema.

Against the allegorical consensus that reads the film as an anxious premonition of 1997, and against the sociological lament for "liquid love," I contend that *Chungking Express* reconceives expiry as the condition of the gift: because time runs out, it can be given. The resulting humanism is "dated" in four registers at once — inscribed with a date, historically superseded, given, and amorous — and it offers a model of the human adequate to a moment that, in Foucault's diagnosis, had already assigned "man" himself a date of invention and a probable end.

*Je ne peins pas l'être. Je peins le passage.*

Michel de Montaigne, *Essais* III.2, "Du repentir" (1588)

失之毫釐，差以千里。

Miss by a hair's breadth, and stray by a thousand *li*.

Sima Qian, *Shiji* 130, "Taishigong zixu," citing the *Changes*

*…car la clef était Fée, et il n'y avait pas moyen de la nettoyer tout à fait.*

Charles Perrault, "La Barbe bleue" (1697)

人生最苦痛的是夢醒了無路可以走。

The most painful thing in life is to wake from a dream and find no road to walk.

Lu Xun, "What Happens After Nora Leaves Home?" (1923)

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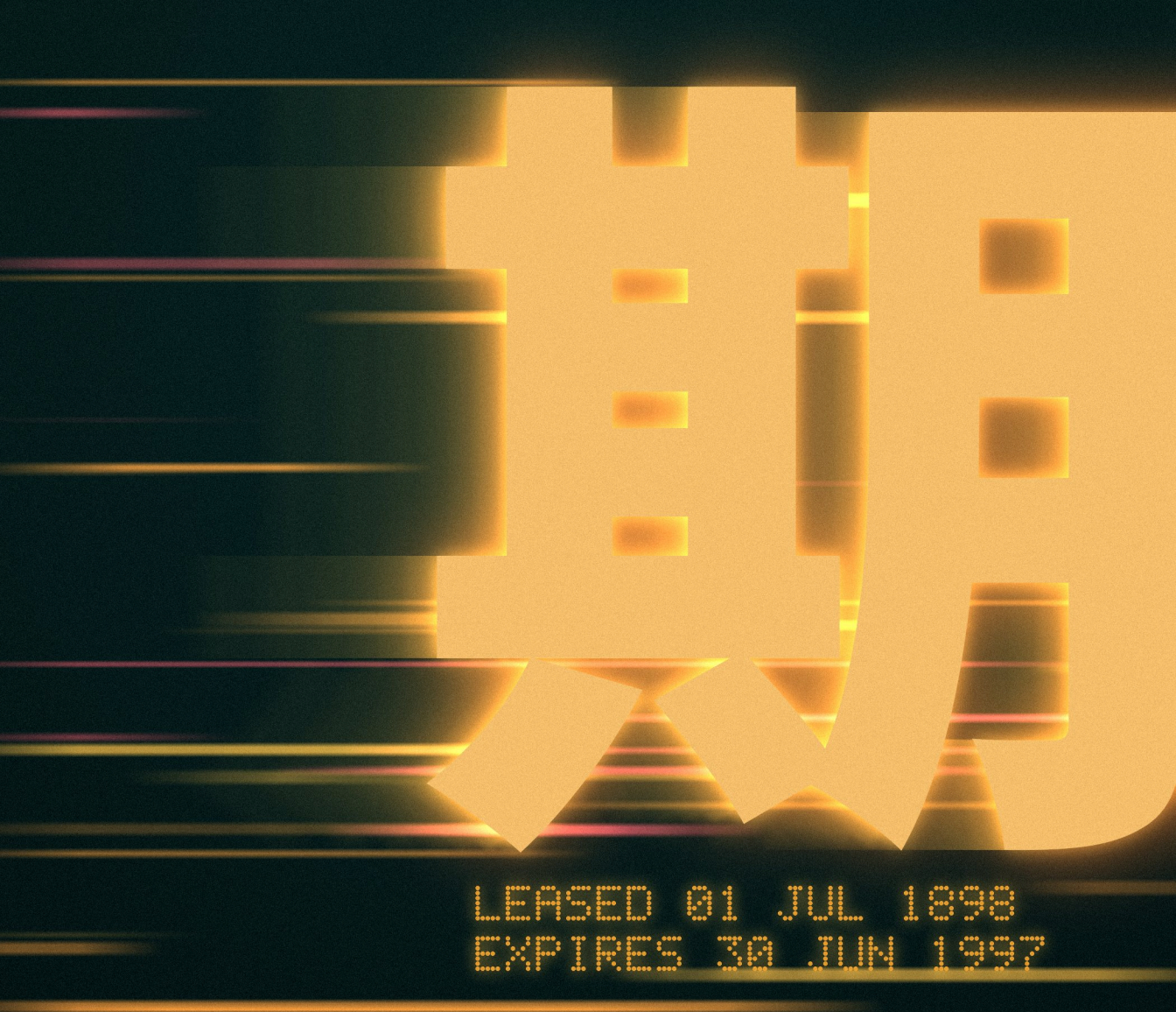
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# Note on Texts, Romanization, and Translation

Dialogue is paraphrased rather than transcribed. The film's dialogue and subtitles remain under copyright, as do several modern texts discussed here, which are likewise paraphrased rather than quoted at length. The film also circulates in non-identical subtitle traditions — the 1994 Hong Kong release, the 1996 North American release through Rolling Thunder Pictures, and the 2020–21 restorations — and paraphrase keeps analytic attention on structure rather than on any single translator's idiom. Cantonese terms are romanized in Jyutping where pronunciation matters, Mandarin in Hanyu Pinyin; characters are traditional, as in the film's Hong Kong release. Translations from classical Chinese, French, German, Danish, and Japanese are my own unless otherwise noted.

The two protagonists of the first and second episodes are designated by their badge numbers, 223 (He Qiwu 何志武, Takeshi Kaneshiro) and 663 (Tony Leung Chiu-wai), following the film's own practice. The unnamed smuggler played by Brigitte Lin Ching-hsia is called "the woman in the blonde wig"; Faye Wong's character, who shares the performer's English name, is called Faye. Claims about intention are avoided throughout. Where a reading depends on historical or linguistic resonance the film does not thematize, it is offered under the Freudian and Althusserian concept of overdetermination, not as a claim about authorial design.




Introduction

# The Dated City

I.1 A Film That Dates
I.2 Argument: Four Data and a Chiasmus
I.3 Historical Coordinates, 1898–2047
I.4 State of the Field
I.5 Method
I.6 Architecture

## I.1 A Film That Dates

*Chungking Express* opens with a measurement and a date. A plainclothes policeman, pursuing a suspect through the arcades of Chungking Mansions, brushes past a woman in a platinum wig; his voice-over records that at their closest they were separated by 0.01 centimetres, and that fifty-seven hours later he would fall in love with her. Before the film has established a single relation between persons, it has established a metric of proximity and a calendar of affect. Every subsequent movement of the film — the thirty tins of pineapple expiring on 1 May, the pager's birthday greeting, the stewardess's letter and keys, the boarding pass drawn on a napkin and dated a year hence — elaborates this inaugural conjunction of the infinitesimal interval and the dated future.

The film was made quickly and has been received as a film about quickness. Wong Kar-wai wrote and shot it in roughly two months in 1994, while *Ashes of Time* (東邪西毒) was in post-production, with Christopher Doyle and Andrew Lau Wai-keung sharing cinematography; it was released in Hong Kong in July 1994 and garlanded at the 1995 Hong Kong Film Awards. Its reputation is that of an exhilarating sketch — hand-held, neon-saturated, scored to a single Mamas & the Papas song played at punishing volume — whose lightness is either its charm or its limit. This thesis takes the lightness as a philosophical achievement. Italo Calvino's *Six Memos for the Next Millennium* (1988) proposed lightness, quickness, exactitude, visibility, and multiplicity as the values literature should carry into the coming century; *Chungking Express*, made six years before the millennium and three before the handover, embodies all five, and it is in its exactitude — its obsessive numbering of hours, centimetres, cans, and badges — that its seriousness is concealed.

## I.2 Argument: Four Data and a Chiasmus

The English word *date* descends from the Latin *data*, the feminine past participle of *dare*, "to give," through the formula with which Roman letters recorded their dispatch: *data Romae*, "given at Rome," followed by the day. A date is etymologically the record of a giving. The romantic sense of the word, the appointed meeting, descends from the same root. *Chungking Express* is constructed around four such data, four objects that are at once given things and technologies of time.

> *A date is etymologically the record of a giving.*

The **can** (罐頭) belongs to 223, who buys a tin of pineapple each day, each stamped to expire on 1 May, as a calendar for the return of a woman who will not return. It is the technology of *conservation*: time sealed, portioned, and dated. The **wig** belongs to the woman in the blonde wig, a smuggler whose platinum hair, raincoat, and dark glasses compose a femininity worn as armour. It is the technology of *masquerade*: time disguised and identity made detachable. The **key** passes from a departing stewardess, through the counter of the Midnight Express snack bar, into Faye's hands, admitting her to 663's flat. It is the technology of *trespass and hospitality*: access to another's time and space. The **boarding pass**, drawn by Faye on a napkin and dated a year ahead, is the technology of *promise*: time given in advance.

Across these four data the film distributes two modalities of relation to time, which I name the *hermeneutics of the label* and the *poetics of relabelling*. The first reads printed dates as destiny. It belongs to the policemen, whose professional habitus of measurement, report, and badge number becomes a form of what I shall call *forensic tenderness*. The second rewrites labels, swaps contents, forges passes, and takes keys that were not addressed to it. It belongs to the film's women. These are positions rather than essences; the film's achievement is to move its characters between them. In the coda, 663 has left the police and bought the snack bar, while Faye returns in a stewardess's uniform: the man takes the counter, the woman takes the sky, and the final exchange surrenders the choice of destination to her. This structural reversal I call the **chiasmus of care**.

The humanism the film articulates is *dated* in four simultaneous senses. It is inscribed with a date, because it locates human dignity in the capacity to mark, keep, and break time. It is historically superseded, because it comes after the anti-humanist critique that pronounced "man" a recent invention with a foreseeable end. It is given, because its paradigmatic act is the gift of time to another. And it is amorous, because its scene is the date, the appointment kept or missed. The wager of this thesis is that these four senses are not a pun but a structure.

## I.3 Historical Coordinates, 1898–2047

Hong Kong in 1994 was a city with a date. On 9 June 1898 the Convention for the Extension of Hong Kong Territory leased the New Territories to Britain for ninety-nine years from 1 July 1898; the lease, rather than any principle, fixed 1997 as the terminus of the colony, because the ceded territories of Hong Kong Island and Kowloon were not viable without the leased hinterland. The Sino-British Joint Declaration of 19 December 1984 converted that terminus into a schedule, and the Basic Law of 1990, in its fifth article, appended a second date: the previous capitalist system and way of life were to remain unchanged for fifty years, which is to say until 2047. Few polities have known both their expiry date and the expiry date of their successor arrangement. Benedict Anderson observed that nations imagine themselves as looming out of an immemorial past and gliding into a limitless future; Hong Kong in 1994 was the negation of that imaginary, a community imagined in the future anterior.

The intervening dates matter to the film's object-world. In May 1967 an industrial dispute at an artificial-flower works in San Po Kong escalated into riots and a bombing campaign against the colonial government, waged by local pro-Communist leftists organized in groups aligned with Beijing and inspired by the Cultural Revolution; their homemade bombs, real and decoy, were known in Cantonese as *boloh* (菠蘿), "pineapples." On 3–4 June 1989 the People's Liberation Army, acting on the orders of the Chinese Communist Party leadership, cleared the democracy movement from Tiananmen Square and the surrounding streets of Beijing with live fire, killing hundreds and possibly thousands of civilians; the government has never permitted an independent count. Emigration from Hong Kong surged in the following years, toward Vancouver, Toronto, Sydney, and California, and Britain's British Nationality (Hong Kong) Act 1990 offered full citizenship to at most fifty thousand selected households. In 1993 the Central–Mid-Levels Escalator opened, and in 1993–94 the Kowloon Walled City was demolished, so that the film was shot between the inauguration of one urban form and the erasure of another. Kai Tak Airport, from which the smuggler's couriers vanish, would close in 1998.

Beneath these political dates runs an economic one. After China's reforms of 1978, Hong Kong's light manufacturing relocated across the border into the Pearl River Delta, and by the early 1990s the colony's economy had become overwhelmingly one of finance, trade, and services. The film registers this transformation with uncanny completeness: no one in *Chungking Express* makes anything. Its characters police, smuggle, serve fast food, staff aircraft, and trade in

the low-end commerce of Chungking Mansions. Yet its domestic interiors are furnished with exactly the goods Hong Kong's factories once exported — wigs, plastic toys, stuffed animals, tinned food. The object-world of the film is an archive of an economy in the act of departure, and Ackbar Abbas's description of Hong Kong culture as *déjà disparu*, already disappeared at the moment of its appearance, applies as much to its things as to its politics.

## I.4 State of the Field

Criticism of *Chungking Express* has crystallized around three hermeneutics. The first is allegorical and has been most powerfully articulated by Abbas, whose *Hong Kong: Culture and the Politics of Disappearance* (1997) and essay on Wong's "erotics of disappointment" read the film's preoccupation with expiry as an encryption of 1997; Stephen Teo, Peter Brunette, and Gina Marchetti have extended, qualified, and historicized this reading. The second is formal and stylistic, exemplified by David Bordwell's account of Wong in *Planet Hong Kong* (2000) and Gary Bettinson's *The Sensuous Cinema of Wong Kar-wai* (2015), which locate the films' power in an aesthetic of disturbance within the conventions of Hong Kong popular cinema. The third is affective and spatial, as in Marc Siegel's study of Wong's intimate spaces, Leung Ping-kwan's work on urban cinema and Hong Kong identity, and Rey Chow's essays on structure and nostalgia in Wong's later films. Studies of Hong Kong masculinities, notably the collection edited by Laikwan Pang and Day Wong (2005), have touched the film's policemen without making them central.

Three lacunae justify the present study. First, the film's philosophical coherence has been treated as mood rather than argument; its concepts of time are noted but not reconstructed. Second, feminist criticism of Wong has concentrated on the later period, on the qipao and the gaze in *In the Mood for Love*, and has tended to treat the women of *Chungking Express* as charming types rather than as agents of the film's thought. Third, Anglophone criticism routes Wong almost exclusively through Godard, Antonioni, Puig, and Murakami, leaving comparatively unexamined the Chinese-language traditions — classical poetics, folk narrative, May Fourth feminism, Hong Kong modernist fiction — through which the film's figures acquire much of their density.

## I.5 Method

The method is constellational in the sense Walter Benjamin and Theodor Adorno gave the term: concepts are arranged around an object so that the object's truth emerges from their configuration rather than from subsumption under any one of them. Each of the four data is therefore surrounded by heterogeneous interlocutors — Marxian, psychoanalytic, phenomenological, feminist, postcolonial, Confucian, Daoist, folkloric — and the thesis claims validity for the configuration, not for any single reading.

Three controls discipline this procedure. Overdetermination, in Freud's account of the dream-work and Althusser's of social contradiction, licenses readings that condense multiple determinations into one figure without claiming that any was intended; the film's improvised production, scripted daily during the shoot, makes it an exemplary *opera aperta* in Umberto Eco's sense. Contrapuntal reading, in Edward Said's formulation, requires that the metropolitan text be read together with what it marginalizes, here the South Asian couriers and the domestic workers absent from its Central. Symptomatic reading, after Pierre Macherey, attends to structured absences. Every interpretive claim is anchored in formal evidence: framing, editing, sound, performance, and the disposition of objects.

## I.6 Architecture

Chapter One analyses the film's form — its *tête-bêche* diptych, its step-printed smear, its dating voice-over, its music, and its topographies — as the material conditions of its thought. Chapters Two through Five take the four data in turn. Chapter Two reads 223's can through Marx, Lukács, Freud, Baudrillard, Heidegger, Kierkegaard, and Proust, and through a genealogy of the tin and the pineapple that runs from Appert to 1898 and 1967. Chapter Three reads the blonde wig through Riviere, Doane, Butler, Bhabha, Fanon, and de Certeau, and through the star text of Brigitte Lin. Chapter Four reads Faye's key through Lacan and Derrida, Rubin and Irigaray, Perrault and the *Soushen houji*, Cixous, Federici, and the classical boudoir lament. Chapter Five reads the boarding pass through Derrida's *Given Time*, Hochschild, the feather-robe tale-type, Lu Xun, and Beauvoir. Chapter Six assembles these readings into the theory of dated humanism, in dialogue with Foucault, Arendt, Confucian *ren*, Nussbaum, Butler, Wynter, and Said, and closes with the film's own expiry and afterlives.




Chapter One

# Tête-Bêche

*Form, Speed, and the Smear*

1.1 The Diptych as Intersection
1.2 The Smear: Step-Printing and the Polychronic Image
1.3 The Voice That Dates
1.4 Sonic Occupation
1.5 Topographies

The form of *Chungking Express* is not a vehicle for its ideas but their first statement. Its two-part structure, its step-printed images, its dating voice-overs, its repetitive music, and its choice of locations together constitute a theory of time before any character articulates one.

## 1.1 The Diptych as Intersection

The film consists of two episodes that share a location, a snack-bar counter, and almost nothing else. The first unfolds in Tsim Sha Tsui, on the Kowloon side, around Chungking Mansions; the second in Central, on Hong Kong Island, around Lan Kwai Fong and the Mid-Levels. The first follows a plainclothes officer, the second a uniformed one. The first borrows the codes of the gangster film and *film noir* (night, rain, guns, narcotics, betrayal); the second borrows those of the romantic comedy and the musical (daylight, a pop song, domestic play). In the first, the woman vanishes; in the second, she returns. In the first, a man tries to make time keep; in the second, a woman makes it move. Each episode is the other's inversion.

The most precise name for this structure comes from Hong Kong literature. Liu Yichang's novella *Duidao* (對倒), first serialized in 1972 and later translated as *Intersection*, follows two strangers through a single Hong Kong day: Chun Yu-pak, an ageing émigré from Shanghai who lives in memory, and Ah Hsing, a young Hong Kong-born woman who lives in fantasy of the future. They pass each other repeatedly, and at one point sit side by side in a cinema, without ever meeting. Liu took his title from philately: *duidao* is the *tête-bêche*, a pair of stamps printed head to tail, one inverted relative to the other, joined at a perforation. Wong would acknowledge Liu explicitly six years later, in the intertitles of *In the Mood for Love* (2000), and again in *2046* (2004). The *tête-bêche* logic, however, is already the structural law of *Chungking Express*: two stories joined at a perforation, each printed upside down relative to the other, so that past-oriented masculine waiting and future-oriented feminine flight are read on a single sheet.

A second model is Murakami Haruki's *Hard-Boiled Wonderland and the End of the World* (1985), whose alternating chapters follow two narrators in apparently unrelated worlds that prove to be one consciousness. Wong's debt to Murakami is inscribed in the film's Chinese title. *Chungking Sammlam* (重慶森林), "Chungking Forest," fuses Chungking Mansions with the *forest* of *Nowei de senlin* (挪威的森林), the Chinese title of *Norwegian Wood* (1987). The English title performs a parallel fusion of the two episodes' locations, Chungking Mansions and the Midnight Express snack bar. Both titles are themselves *tête-*

*bêche*: compounds of two places that never meet. A third episode, conceived for the project and excised, became *Fallen Angels* (1995), so that the diptych is itself the remainder of a broken triptych.

The point of intersection is a collision. At the end of the first episode, 223 brushes past Faye at the counter, and his voice-over measures the distance and announces that six hours later she would fall for another man. The narrative baton passes through contact, not causality. The Chinese character that best names this junction is *jiao* (交). The *Shuowen jiezi* glosses its graph as crossed shins, a human figure standing with legs crossed; its semantic field extends to crossing (交叉), handing over (交給), exchange (交換), friendship (交朋友), sexual union (交合), and the transfer of sovereignty (交接), the term for the 1997 ceremony. *Chungking Express* is a film of *jiao*: its structure crosses, its objects are handed over, its relations are exchanges between strangers, and its historical horizon is a handover. The X at its centre is not an abstract chiasmus but a body crossing.

> *“ The X at its centre is not an abstract chiasmus but a body crossing.*

## 1.2 The Smear: Step-Printing and the Polychronic Image

The film’s signature image is the smear. Shot at a low frame rate with a slow shutter, the footage is printed with each frame duplicated to restore projection speed. The result is a stuttering, streaked movement in which bodies leave luminous trails, as if the image were exposed for longer than an instant and released later than it should be. In the most celebrated instance, Faye watches 663 drink coffee at the counter while the crowd around them dissolves into velocity. The two figures, moving deliberately for an undercranked camera, appear at a near-normal tempo; everyone else becomes a blur.

This shot materializes what Ernst Bloch called the *simultaneity of the non-simultaneous* (*Gleichzeitigkeit des Ungleichzeitigen*). Two temporalities share a frame without sharing a time: the lovers inhabit duration, the city inhabits speed. I call this the *polychronic image*. It answers, by technical means, Henri Bergson’s critique in *Creative Evolution* (1907) of the “cinematographical mechanism of thought,” by which the intellect takes snapshots of becoming and reconstitutes movement from immobile sections. Step-printing exposes both halves of that mechanism at once. The stutter reveals the discontinuity of the

frames; the smear reveals the duration that the frames cannot contain. The film thereby performs on itself the Bergsonian critique of cinema while demonstrating, with Gilles Deleuze, that cinema can nonetheless give time directly. In Deleuze's terms the smear is a time-image: movement becomes aberrant, the sensory-motor link slackens, and the characters become seers (*voyants*) rather than agents, absorbed by pure optical situations.

Paul Virilio's *Esthétique de la disparition* (1980) supplies a further concept. *Picnolepsy* names the frequent micro-absences of consciousness, lapses so brief that the subject does not notice them and stitches time back together across the gap. For Virilio, cinema is the technical exploitation of picnoleptic gaps, the persistence of vision that conceals the black intervals between frames. The smear makes the gap visible. It is picnolepsy rendered as image, and it is fitting that Abbas's *politics of disappearance* draws on Virilio, since a city about to vanish is pictured here as a crowd that vanishes in the act of being filmed.

The smear also has a lineage in the visual arts. Étienne-Jules Marey's chronophotography, Giacomo Balla's *Dynamism of a Dog on a Leash* (1912), and Marcel Duchamp's *Nude Descending a Staircase, No. 2* (1912) decomposed motion into superimposed phases; Duchamp's descending figure finds its mechanical successor in the Mid-Levels Escalator. Within Chinese aesthetics the closer analogue is *feibai* (飛白), "flying white," the calligraphic stroke in which a fast, dry brush leaves streaks of bare paper inside the ink, so that speed is inscribed as interruption. The step-printed crowd is cinematic *feibai*. The film will end with a second smear of exactly this kind: Faye's ink boarding pass, blurred by rain. Walter Benjamin's *optical unconscious*, the dimension of movement revealed only by slow motion and enlargement, and Laura Mulvey's later account of stillness within the moving image in *Death 24x a Second* (2006), name the stakes. The smear is where the film shows its own time.

## 1.3 The Voice That Dates

The voice-overs of *Chungking Express* do not narrate events; they date them. Fifty-seven hours, six hours, thirty cans, the first of May, a year: the voice converts encounters into intervals and intervals into prolepses. In Gérard Genette's terms, the prolepsis anticipates; in Roland Barthes's terms, it installs the future anterior. Barthes, contemplating Alexander Gardner's photograph of the condemned Lewis Payne in *Camera Lucida* (1980), found in it the vertiginous tense of a death that both will be and has been. The voice-over performs the same operation on the moving image. When 223 announces that fifty-seven hours

later he would be in love, the image of the collision becomes retrospective at the moment of its appearance, a present already archived.

Émile Benveniste distinguished *discours*, anchored in an "I" and a "now," from *histoire*, the impersonal past of narrated events. The policemen's voice-overs fuse the two into what might be called *dated discourse*: first-person confession delivered in the measured cadence of the incident report. This is the acoustic form of *forensic tenderness*, the policeman's professional precision redirected toward love. Kaja Silverman's *The Acoustic Mirror* (1988) showed that classical cinema reserved the disembodied voice-over largely for men, as a position of narrative authority, while confining women's voices to the body and the diegesis. *Chungking Express* both repeats and undoes this pattern. Its two policemen hold the voice-over, but it confers no mastery on them: 223 is wrong about May, wrong about the woman in the wig, and wrong about Faye; 663 cannot read the letter addressed to him. The masculine voice measures without knowing.

Faye, the film's most decisive agent, is never given voice-over narration. Her interiority is expressed through action and through song. Above all it is expressed through the voice of Faye Wong herself, whose Cantonese recording of "Dreams" (夢中人) rises over the film's final passages. The female voice here exits the diegesis not as narrator but as star, in what Michel Chion would call an acousmatic register, a voice whose source exceeds the image. That voice is also a commodity, circulating on cassettes and compact discs through the Cantopop industry, and the film does not pretend otherwise. Its feminism will be one of tactical occupation within commodity forms, not of escape from them.

## 1.4 Sonic Occupation

Faye plays "California Dreamin'" (1965) at the Midnight Express on what seems an infinite loop, at a volume that renders conversation nearly impossible. The repetition is not characterization but territorialization. Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari, in the plateau "Of the Refrain" in *A Thousand Plateaus* (1980), describe the child who sings in the dark to organize a fragile home against chaos, then extends the refrain outward until it opens onto the cosmos. Faye's song performs both movements. It claims the counter as her territory within someone else's business, and it names an elsewhere, California, toward which it will eventually carry her. The refrain is a deterritorialization machine disguised as a habit.

Jacques Attali's *Noise* (1977) described the twentieth century as the era of *repetition*, in which mass-reproduced music replaces representation and stockpiles

time in recorded form. Faye's tape is repetition in Attali's sense, and the film's soundtrack constitutes a small lexicon of time: Dennis Brown's "Things in Life" in the first episode's bar, Dinah Washington's "What a Diff'rence a Day Makes," the dream of an elsewhere, the dream of a person. "Dreams" itself was first recorded by the Irish band the Cranberries in 1992; Faye Wong's 1994 Cantonese version gives it new words over the same melody. A cover is a relabelled can, the same contents under a new label. The film's music thus anticipates the poetics of relabelling that its heroine will practise on 663's tins.

## 1.5 Topographies

Chungking Mansions, completed in 1961 on Nathan Road, is a seventeen-storey complex of guesthouses, curry houses, money changers, and wholesale stalls, the node of what the anthropologist Gordon Mathews has called *low-end globalization*: trade conducted in cash and small quantities by South Asian and African merchants. The film's opening chase through its ground-floor arcades invites Benjamin's analysis of the Parisian arcade as the dream-house of the collective, where commodities glow as phantasmagoria. It equally exemplifies Michel Foucault's *heterotopia*, the real place in which several incompatible sites are juxtaposed, and Siegfried Kracauer's essay on the hotel lobby, where guests share a space without sharing a relation. The building is also a survivor. Its more notorious double, the Kowloon Walled City, was being demolished as the film was made.

The Midnight Express, on the edge of Lan Kwai Fong, is a counter rather than a room. Mikhail Bakhtin identified the *chronotope of the threshold* as the site of crisis and decisive encounter, where time is compressed into the instant; the counter is that threshold, the line across which food, money, letters, keys, and glances pass. It belongs, with the airport, the convenience store, and the hotel, to what Marc Augé in 1992 termed *non-places* (*non-lieux*), spaces of transit and transaction that produce solitary contractuality rather than identity. The film's wager is that non-places can be inhabited, and that the counter can become what Hannah Arendt called a world, the table that simultaneously relates and separates. Chapter Six will return to this claim.

The Central–Mid-Levels Escalator, opened in 1993, carries commuters uphill through residential streets on a schedule: downhill in the morning rush, uphill for the rest of the day. It is a chronopolitical machine, its direction programmed by the clock, and it is a membrane: the public infrastructure runs within a few metres of private windows. 663's flat, reportedly Christopher Doyle's own,

stands beside it, and Faye, riding past, looks in. Michel de Certeau opposed the voyeur-god atop the World Trade Center, who reads the city as a text, to the walkers below, who write it with their steps. Faye is neither. She is a conveyed watcher at mid-height, borne by a machine while she looks, in the band of the city named for its intermediacy. The verticality is historically charged. Until 1930 the Peak District (Reservation) Ordinance of 1904 reserved the summit of the island for non-Chinese residents, and the island's slope remains a gradient of class. Faye's ascent of that gradient is the first movement of a trajectory that will end in the air.




Chapter Two

# The Can

*Conservation, Commodity, and the Work of Mourning*

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2.1 Canned Time
2.2 A Genealogy of the Tin
2.3 Mourning by Instalment
2.4 Being-Toward-Expiry
2.5 Hydraulics of Feeling
2.6 Ten Thousand Years
2.7 Love at Last Sight

The can is the film's first datum and its master-object. Through it the film poses its founding question, whether anything in the world does not expire, and gives its first answer, provisional and mistaken: that love can be kept if it is properly dated. This chapter reconstructs the can as a technology of time, traces the genealogy that makes 223's tins of pineapple a condensation of empire, war, and disguise, and reads his ritual as a mourning that is also a philosophy. Its argument is that the can embodies the *hermeneutics of the label* in its purest form, and that the film's wish for ten thousand years does not abolish the expiry date but extends it into a dated eternity.

## 2.1 Canned Time

223's voice-over states the founding observation as a discovery belated in its own telling: at some point he began to notice that everything carries a date — the saury expires, the canned meat expires, even the cling film expires — and he begins to wonder whether anything in the world does not. The list is a phenomenology of the supermarket shelf. Its objects are packaged things rather than natural ones, and their dates are those of the printer rather than of growth and decay. Open dating, the sell-by, best-before, and use-by stamps that became general across retail economies in the 1970s, has become for 223 an ontology. He lives in a world in which being is shelf life, in a city whose largest convenience-store chain is named for a timetable.

> *He lives in a world in which being is shelf life.*

Marx began *Capital* (1867) by observing that the commodity, apparently a trivial thing, is in truth a very strange one, because in it the social relations between producers take the form of a relation between products. His figure for value is culinary: the commodity is a mere *Gallerte*, a jelly or aspic, of undifferentiated human labour — labour congealed and preserved. The can is value's literal form, labour and time sealed in tin and stored against the future. 223 inverts the fetish without dispelling it. Where the fetishist mistakes a relation among persons for a property of things, 223 knowingly entrusts a relation among persons to things and asks the tins to carry what May no longer will. His fetishism is deliberate, and its deliberateness is its pathos: he knows the tins are not May, and he buys them anyway.

Georg Lukács's "Reification and the Consciousness of the Proletariat" (1923) described how, under rationalized production, time loses its qualitative, flowing character and freezes into a measurable continuum filled with measurable things; time, in short, becomes space. 223's ritual literalizes the description. Thirty days become thirty tins, and the duration of waiting becomes a row of objects that can be counted, stacked, and eaten. Bergson's *Time and Free Will* (1889) had argued that to count moments of duration one must set them side by side in an imaginary space, since only juxtaposition permits number. 223's tins externalize that space: a Bergsonian error turned into a domestic practice. E. P. Thompson's account of industrial time-discipline (1967) and Moishe Postone's of abstract time (1993) name the social forms that make such counting habitual. The policeman, whose shifts, beats, and reports are clocked, embodies that regime, and 223 brings work-discipline home and applies it to love.

The can is also the paradigmatic object of what Heidegger, in "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954), named *Bestand*, standing-reserve: the mode in which technology reveals beings as stock, on call, ordered to stand by for further ordering. Canned fruit is no longer fruit; it is a reserve of calories immobilized against time. Heidegger's own example of standing-reserve, tellingly, is an airliner waiting on a runway, the object toward which the film will eventually lift its heroine. In "The Thing" (1950) he set against the technological object the humble jug, whose thinghood lies in the void that holds and in the outpouring it gives; the jug's essence is the gift of the pour (*Geschenk des Gusses*), the libation that gathers earth and sky, mortals and divinities. The can is the jug's negation. Its void is evacuated rather than offered; it does not pour but must be broken open with a tool; once emptied it is waste. 223 buys a tin of pineapple each day because May loved pineapple, so each tin is meant as an offering. The offering has no recipient, and the libation turns back upon the giver: on the last night, he eats them all.

Andy Warhol's thirty-two Campbell's soup cans (1962) and Piero Manzoni's ninety tins of *Merda d'artista* (1961) mark the poles of the can's modern semiotics. Warhol's series exhibits seriality, each canvas differing only by its label. Manzoni's tins, priced by weight against gold, exhibit the epistemology of the seal: their contents can be verified only by destroying them as objects, so that their being is exhausted by their labels. 223 lives at the Manzoni pole. He never doubts what his tins contain; he reads only their dates. This is the *hermeneutics of the label*: the conviction that a thing's truth is printed on its surface by an authority one does not question, and that the reader's task is to submit to the

printed date as destiny. Its affective style is forensic tenderness, a policeman's patience applied to a heart. The date he reads is 1 May: his birthday, the name of his absent beloved, and, as Chapter Three will argue, the international festival of labour.

That every tin bears the same date is not trivial. In "Signature Event Context" (1972), Derrida argued that a mark functions only on condition of iterability, its capacity to be repeated in other contexts. In *Shibboleth: For Paul Celan* (1986) he extended the argument to the date, which marks a singular event yet becomes legible only by returning, every year, as an anniversary. Celan had suggested in his Meridian address (1960) that every poem keeps its own "20th of January" inscribed within it, the date on which Büchner's Lenz walked through the mountains. 223's tins are thirty copies of one date, iterability made into inventory. The film's question is therefore not whether things expire but what it means for a singular love to be marked by a repeatable date.

## 2.2 A Genealogy of the Tin

The tin can was born of war. Nicolas Appert's method of preserving food by heating it in sealed vessels, developed during the Napoleonic Wars and published in 1810 as *L'Art de conserver*, won a government prize because armies march on their provisions. In the same year Peter Durand obtained a British patent for preserving food in vessels that included tin, and by 1813 Bryan Donkin and John Hall's works at Bermondsey were supplying the Royal Navy. For decades cans were opened with hammer and chisel; dedicated openers appeared only in the 1850s. The can preceded its own opening, a technology of sealing whose release was an afterthought. Tins supplied to Franklin's Arctic expedition of 1845 were long blamed, in a hypothesis now contested, for the lead that poisoned its crews. From the beginning the can was an imperial vessel, carrying the time of home into foreign spaces.

The pineapple's itinerary is equally imperial. Columbus encountered the fruit on Guadeloupe in 1493. Its English name is itself a relabelling: *pineapple* first meant the pine cone and was transferred to the American fruit in the seventeenth century, while most European languages adopted the Tupi-derived *ananas*. In early modern Europe it was a token of luxury and welcome, and Charles II was painted receiving one. Its canning, however, is a history of plantations. In 1898, the year Britain leased the New Territories for ninety-nine years, the United States annexed Hawaii, five years after American businessmen had overthrown its monarchy and installed Sanford Dole's government. In 1901

James Dole founded the Hawaiian Pineapple Company, and Hawaii became the capital of the canned fruit. The Treaty of Paris of December 1898 delivered the Philippines to the United States, later the site of vast pineapple estates on Mindanao. In Japanese Taiwan, pineapple canning became a major export industry between the wars; in Singapore and Malaya, Chinese entrepreneurs, Tan Kah Kee among them, built canneries whose profits flowed into rubber, schools, and politics. By the 1990s Thailand and the Philippines dominated the trade. A tin of pineapple bought in a Hong Kong convenience store in 1994 was the terminus of four centuries of colonial botany and a century of plantation capital, and the annexation that made Hawaii its capital shares a year with the lease that dated the city.

In Cantonese the pineapple (菠蘿) carries two further connotations. The first is gentle. The pineapple bun (菠蘿包), Hong Kong's emblematic bakery item, contains no pineapple; it is named for a crackled sugar crust that resembles the fruit's skin. It is a label without contents, a name that survives the absence of its referent, which is precisely the structure of 223's love for May. The second is violent. During the 1967 riots against the colonial government, pro-Communist leftist militants planted homemade bombs, called pineapples, across the city: thousands of suspected devices, most of them decoys, some bearing a label warning compatriots to keep away (同胞勿近). On 20 August 1967 a bomb wrapped to look like a gift, placed by leftist bombers in a street in North Point, killed eight-year-old Wong Yee-man and her two-year-old brother. By the time the disturbances ended, fifty-one people had died, among them civilians and police officers killed by bombs and rioters shot by police. Marcel Mauss, in a short essay of 1924, observed that the German *Gift* means both gift and poison; the bombers' gift-wrapped device is the gift in its most poisonous form. The pineapple of 1967 is the decoy, the false label, and the lethal gift.

The first episode of *Chungking Express*, in which a man eats thirty tins of pineapple and then falls in love with a woman carrying a gun, sets the gentle and violent senses side by side. I do not claim that the film alludes to 1967. I claim that its central fruit is overdetermined by a local history in which pineapple named both sweetness and explosive, both label and decoy, and that the film's distinction between reading labels and rewriting them, between conservation and disguise, unfolds within this field. Relabelling is not innocent. In the hands of the 1967 bombers it disguised a weapon as a gift; in Faye's it will serve care.

## 2.3 Mourning by Instalment

223's ritual has the structure of the work of mourning described in Freud's "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917). Reality-testing shows that the loved object is gone and demands that libido be withdrawn from it, but the demand cannot be met at once. It is carried out piece by piece, at great cost of time and energy: each memory and expectation bound to the object is brought up, overcharged, and released in turn. 223's tins externalize and schedule this work: one memory, one tin, one day. It is mourning by instalment, the emotional analogue of the hire-purchase plan, and its premise is that grief, like debt, can be amortized.

The climax departs from Freud's model. On the last night of April, after telephoning women from his past who have forgotten him or moved on, 223 eats the accumulated tins at a single sitting. Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok distinguished introjection, the gradual enlargement of the self through the assimilation of loss, from incorporation, the fantasy of swallowing the lost object whole so as not to mourn it. Incorporation produces the *crypt*, an inner tomb in which the unmourned object is preserved, alive and secret. The can is a crypt in the literal sense, a sealed vessel that preserves its contents beyond their season, and the devouring of thirty tins is incorporation staged as a meal. Derrida's preface to Abraham and Torok's study of the Wolf Man, "Fors" (1976), described the crypt as a place inside the self that remains outside it, a foreign body sealed within. The first episode asks whether 223 will remain a cryptophore, carrying the sealed beloved, or whether the crypt will be opened.

Proust's madeleine supplies the counter-model. In *Swann's Way* (1913) the narrator observes that voluntary memory yields only lifeless information, that the past lies hidden in some material object we do not suspect, and that chance alone decides whether we meet it before we die. A crumb of cake soaked in tea releases Combray entire. 223's tins attempt to manufacture a madeleine on a schedule, to bring involuntary memory under voluntary control, and they fail by design. A taste repeated daily becomes habit, and habit, as Samuel Beckett argued in his essay on Proust (1931), is the dull compromise that shields the self from the real.

Walter Benjamin offers a third model. In the fragments known as "Central Park," he wrote that the souvenir is the complement of isolated experience (*Erlebnis*): as the relic derives from the corpse, the souvenir derives from dead experience, which euphemistically calls itself *Erlebnis*. Susan Stewart's *On Longing* (1984) extended the analysis: the souvenir replaces the context of experience with the narrative of its possessor, and the collection replaces history

with classification. Jean Baudrillard's *The System of Objects* (1968) added that the collection abolishes real time by translating it into a serial order the collector controls, and that what the collector finally collects is himself. 223's tins confirm Baudrillard with uncanny literalness. Their shared date is his own birthday, so the series he assembles in May's name converges on himself. They are souvenirs of a love already dead, collected, classified, and dated to the day of his birth.

The crypt and the souvenir differ in one respect that matters for the film. The crypt preserves its object in secret; the souvenir displays it. 223 conducts his mourning in public — at a counter, in a shop, and in a voice-over addressed to the audience. His grief is exhibited, and in being exhibited it begins to change.

## 2.4 Being-Toward-Expiry

In *Being and Time* (1927), Heidegger described death as Dasein's ownmost possibility: non-relational, certain, and indefinite as to its when. Authenticity anticipates this possibility as one's own; inauthenticity flees it into the anonymous "they" (*das Man*), for whom death is something that happens to someone, eventually, but not yet. The expiry date inverts this structure. It is certain *and* definite; it is printed by an anonymous authority rather than anticipated by oneself; and it concerns a thing rather than oneself. To read one's love on a label is to fall, in the precise sense of Heidegger's *Verfallen*, into the world of the they. German, with an irony Heidegger might have relished, calls the expiry date the *Verfallsdatum*, the date of falling. 223's being-toward-expiry is fallenness in dated form: he has handed the question of his love's end to a printer.

Hong Kong in 1994 was an experiment in being-toward-expiry on the scale of a city. Its end was certain and dated; the date had been printed by others, in London and Beijing; and its people were alternately urged to anticipate it, by emigrating or securing passports, and to flee it into business as usual. On 31 August 1994, seven weeks after the film's release, the Standing Committee of the National People's Congress resolved that the legislature to be elected under Chris Patten's reforms would end on 30 June 1997, derailing the "through train" that had been meant to carry institutions across the handover. Even the vocabulary of continuity was one of express transport, and in 1994 the express was cancelled. The film's two policemen embody the responses Heidegger's analysis allows. 223 lives the date as fate; 663 tries not to read it at all, leaving a letter unread.

Kierkegaard's *Repetition* (1843) supplies the more exact diagnosis. Its pseudonymous author, Constantin Constantius, distinguishes recollection,

which repeats backward what has been, from repetition proper, which recollects forward. The young man of the book falls in love and at once begins to recollect his love; the girl becomes the occasion of a poetic longing, and the relationship is essentially over before it has begun. 223 is this young man. The woman matters less than the ritual of remembering her, and on the last night of April he resolves to fall in love with whichever woman next enters the bar. Constantin's figure for love's three temporalities is sartorial. Hope is a new garment, stiff and glossy, never yet tried on; recollection is a discarded garment one has outgrown, however beautiful; repetition is an indestructible garment that fits closely and tenderly, neither binding nor sagging. The film dresses its women in these garments. The woman in the wig wears a garment of recollection, a disguise borrowed from cinema's past; Faye will finally put on a uniform that is, in Kierkegaard's sense, repetition. In *Either/Or* (1843), the address "The Unhappiest One" describes the person whose hope is directed at what should be remembered and whose memory is directed at what should be hoped. Hoping for the return of a woman who has left, and remembering a woman he barely met, 223 is the unhappiest one of the first episode.

Zygmunt Bauman's *Liquid Love* (2003) made the expiry date an emblem of modern intimacy: consumer culture, he argued, teaches us to treat partners as goods with built-in obsolescence, enjoyed until further notice and replaced when a better offer appears. The first episode seems to illustrate the thesis, since 223 resolves to love the next woman to enter the bar. Yet the film inverts Bauman at every point. The tins are not disposal but fidelity; the expiry date is a deadline 223 sets himself in order to *keep* loving for a month; and his response to expiry is not replacement but memory. Kant's distinction in the *Groundwork* (1785) between what has a price, and can be replaced by an equivalent, and what has a dignity, and admits no equivalent, states the dilemma exactly. The tins have a price; the memory they are meant to hold is supposed to have a dignity. The film asks whether dignity can survive dating. Its answer, developed in Chapters Five and Six, is that dignity may lie precisely in how a dated thing is given.

## 2.5 Hydraulics of Feeling

223 explains that when he is unhappy he goes running, because running drains water from the body and leaves none for tears. The theory is hydraulic. It treats the body as a reservoir of fixed volume in which fluids are interchangeable, so that what leaves as sweat cannot leave as tears. It also has, unknown to its

author, a long pedigree. William James argued in "What Is an Emotion?" (1884) that bodily expression is not the effect of feeling but its cause: we feel sorry because we cry. 223 practises the James–Lange theory as therapy: abolish the crying and the sorrow will not occur. Breuer and Freud's *Studies on Hysteria* (1895) treated strangulated affect as a quantity requiring discharge, and Freud's economic model retained the language of quantities, pressures, and outflows; Konrad Lorenz later diagrammed instinct as a reservoir with a valve. Descartes, in the *Passions of the Soul* (1649), derived tears and sweat from one substance, vapours that condense into water at the body's surface and differ only in the organ through which they exit. 223 has rediscovered Descartes.

Classical Chinese medicine offers a more intricate economy. The *Suwen* of the *Huangdi Neijing* assigns each of the five viscera its own fluid: 心為汗，肝為淚 — the heart's fluid is sweat; the liver's is tears. In this physiology sweat is not a neutral alternative to tears. It is the fluid of the heart itself, the seat of spirit and joy. 223 believes he is diverting grief from his eyes, but in the *Neijing*'s terms he is weeping through his heart. The film does not cite the *Neijing*. Its hydraulic comedy is nonetheless overdetermined by a medical culture in which the circulation of fluids is the circulation of feeling, and 223's running is less an evasion of grief than its translation into a more intimate organ.

The individual body's hydraulics have a civic analogue. Hong Kong cannot water itself. During the drought of 1963 supply was cut to four hours every four days, and from 1965 the colony drew most of its water from the Dongjiang under an agreement with the Guangdong authorities. The city's body depended hydraulically on the sovereign to which it would revert. Across the diptych, water carries affect: rain drenches the first episode's nights; 663's flat, in the second, appears to weep; and the film ends with rain smearing the ink of a paper boarding pass. 223's attempt to dry his body is the first episode's way of not feeling. The second reverses it: there, a man learns that his rooms are crying.

## 2.6 Ten Thousand Years

At the close of the first episode, 223 states the film's most famous proposition. If memory were a tin, he hopes it would never expire; and if a date must be added, he hopes it will be ten thousand years. The numeral is not arbitrary. 萬, ten thousand, is the classical Chinese figure of the uncountable, as in the ten thousand things of creation (萬物) and the ten thousand ages of history (萬古). 萬歲, "ten thousand years," was the acclamation addressed to emperors and, in

the twentieth century, to the Party and its Chairman. In a *ci* poem of 1963 replying to Guo Moruo, Mao Zedong declared ten thousand years too long and urged that the morning and evening be seized. 223 wishes for exactly the span the revolutionary had rejected, and he wishes it for a memory rather than a state.

The Chinese tradition knows two classic figures of love's duration. The first is the adynaton. In the Han ballad "Shang xie" (上邪), the speaker vows to part from her beloved only when mountains lose their peaks, rivers run dry, thunder rolls in winter, snow falls in summer, and heaven and earth merge — that is, never. The second is the confession of finitude. Bai Juyi's *Song of Everlasting Sorrow* (806) ends by conceding that heaven and earth, however long they last, will end, while sorrow alone runs on without term: 天長地久有時盡，此恨綿綿無絕期. 223 takes neither path. He does not swear by the impossible, and he does not claim eternity for sorrow. He asks for a date, vast but finite. His wish is the hyperbole of the expiry date, not its abolition. Here the film first formulates dated humanism: even the wish for permanence must take the form of a calendar.

> *Even the wish for permanence must take the form of a calendar.*

Zhuangzi supplies the cosmology in which such a wish is neither tragic nor absurd. In the first chapter of the *Zhuangzi*, the morning mushroom knows nothing of the month and the summer cicada nothing of spring and autumn, while the great *chun* tree of antiquity takes eight thousand years for a spring and eight thousand for an autumn. Lifespans are incommensurable, and none is deficient by another's measure; the morning mushroom's life is complete. The seventh chapter of the *Laozi* adds an ethical condition: heaven and earth endure because they do not live for themselves. If endurance follows from not living for oneself, a love that would last ten thousand years must be a love that gives its time away. 223, who keeps his tins to himself, cannot meet the condition. Faye will.

The European tradition offers the monument: Horace's ode, built more lasting than bronze; Shakespeare's sixty-fifth sonnet, hoping that in black ink his love may still shine bright. The can is a pop-modern monument, preserving its content for a few years in tin-plated steel. The fate of 223's phrase shows the monument's paradox, because the phrase has outlived its film. In early 1995

Jeffrey Lau's *A Chinese Odyssey Part Two: Cinderella*, starring Stephen Chow, parodied Wong's formula. Its narrator observes that a sword was 0.01 centimetres from his throat and that within a quarter of an incense stick its mistress would love him, because he had resolved to lie; the vow he then speaks asks that, if a term must be set on his love, it be ten thousand years. Wong's clock-time is translated into incense-time, and his sincerity into a lie that the film later reveals to be true. Lau's film became a cult text among mainland university students in the late 1990s, so that the expiring colony's vocabulary of dated love crossed the border and became the mainland's idiom of eternal love. The phrase was relabelled and recanned, and its migration enacts this chapter's thesis: a dated thing given away outlasts what is hoarded.

In the same year as *Chungking Express*, Tsai Ming-liang's *Vive L'Amour* (愛情萬歲, literally "love, ten thousand years") won the Golden Lion at Venice. Its plot of a key taken from a door and an empty flat secretly inhabited will return in Chapter Four. Two films of 1994, from two of the Chinese societies then outside the People's Republic, lent the numeral of imperial acclamation to love, and both placed a forest in an unlikely urban site: Wong's in his Chinese title, Tsai's in the still-unfinished Daan Forest Park, where his heroine weeps in the final shot.

## 2.7 Love at Last Sight

The film's opening measurement, 0.01 centimetres, measures a near miss. Baudelaire's sonnet "À une passante" (1860) gave the modern city its paradigmatic encounter: in the deafening street a tall woman in mourning passes, the poet glimpses her, and she is gone — *Un éclair… puis la nuit!* — leaving him to address her across the impossibility of meeting: *Ô toi que j'eusse aimée, ô toi qui le savais!* Benjamin's reading in "On Some Motifs in Baudelaire" (1939) named the structure: love not at first sight but at last sight. 223's voice-over accomplishes something Baudelaire's could not. It dates the last sight and promises a sequel — fifty-seven hours later he would love her — so that the passing becomes the first term of a calendar. The woman he brushes past is, like Baudelaire's, veiled, by a wig rather than by mourning, and she is in flight.

Simmel's "The Metropolis and Mental Life" (1903) explains why such encounters proliferate. The metropolis multiplies contacts and enforces punctuality; Simmel imagined that if every clock in Berlin went wrong by an hour, the city's economic and communicative life would collapse. Its inhabitants defend themselves with reserve, a blasé indifference that lets them pass thousands of

strangers without registering any. A Chinese proverb holds that those bound by *yuanfen* (緣分) will meet across a thousand *li*, while those without it pass face to face without meeting: 有緣千里來相會，無緣對面不相逢. 223's 0.01 centimetres is the second half of the proverb measured with a policeman's rule. The film's first voice-over generalizes the point — every day we brush past many people who might one day become friends or confidants — and its structure tests it twice, once with the woman in the wig and once with Faye.

A distance of 0.01 centimetres is also, in a sense, infinite. Zeno argued that a moving body must first cross half of any interval, then half the remainder, and so never arrives; Achilles never overtakes the tortoise. In *Otherwise than Being* (1974), Levinas distinguished proximity from spatial nearness: proximity is not a minimal distance but a restlessness of responsibility for the other, a nearness that grows the more it is answered. The film's opening collision is nearness without proximity, and its arc across both episodes converts the one into the other. Sima Qian's dictum, cited in this thesis's epigraph, states the stakes: miss by a hair's breadth, and stray by a thousand *li*. The classical measure of the near miss is the hair (毫), and the hair at the film's opening is not the woman's own. It is a wig.




Chapter Three

# The Wig

## *Masquerade, Mimicry, and* la Perruque

3.1 Womanliness as Weaponry
3.2 The Colonial Blonde
3.3 Tactics of the Weak
3.4 Behind Dark Glasses
3.5 The Star Who Vanishes
3.6 Chungking's Margins
3.7 Sealed Off
3.8 Executing the Master

The second datum is worn rather than consumed. The woman in the blonde wig is the film's most heavily armoured figure: platinum hair, belted raincoat, dark glasses, high heels, a gun. Where 223 preserves a content against time, she preserves a self against others' eyes. This chapter reads her costume as a technology of masquerade that is at once psychoanalytic, colonial, tactical, and stellar. It argues that the film presents masquerade as the first feminine response to a dated world: a survival strategy that preserves its wearer by making her identity detachable, but which can end only in exit.

## 3.1 Womanliness as Weaponry

Joan Riviere's "Womanliness as a Masquerade" (1929) began from a clinical paradox: a successful intellectual woman who, after speaking in public with authority, compulsively sought reassurance by flirting with the paternal men in her audience. Riviere concluded that womanliness could be assumed and worn as a mask, both to hide the possession of masculine capacities and to avert the reprisals expected if they were discovered. More radically, she denied any difference between such masquerade and genuine womanliness: they were the same thing. The woman in the wig turns Riviere's case inside out. Her masquerade does not hide masculine power behind feminine compliance. It displays an exaggerated femininity as the uniform of a trade in which she commands men, carries a gun, and kills. Femininity is her armour, not her alibi.

> *"Femininity is her armour, not her alibi.*

Lacan's "The Signification of the Phallus" (1958) described femininity as a parade in which the woman seeks to be what she does not have. Luce Irigaray, in *This Sex Which Is Not One* (1977), turned the analysis into a strategy: a woman might deliberately assume the feminine role, playing with mimesis, in order to convert subordination into affirmation and expose what the role conceals. Mary Ann Doane's "Film and the Masquerade" (1982) brought Riviere into film theory. By flaunting femininity, she argued, the masquerade manufactures a distance from the image, letting the woman hold her image at arm's length rather than coincide with it. Doane's later *Femmes Fatales* (1991) described the noir woman as an epistemological threat, never what she seems. The woman in the wig reverses even this: she is exactly what she seems, a professional, and it is the men around her who are not. Judith Butler's *Gender Trouble* (1990) radi-

calized the analysis: drag, by imitating gender, reveals that gender is itself imitative, a citation without an original.

The woman in the wig is a figure of citationality. Her look is assembled from cinema: the noir femme fatale, the Hitchcock blonde, and Gena Rowlands's *Gloria* (1980), to which it is often traced. In *Vertigo* (1958), Scottie forces Judy to dye her hair platinum and restyle it as the dead Madeleine's; blondness there is a masquerade imposed by a man's necrophilic desire. The woman in the wig chooses her blondness, and the man she will kill is the man who believes he owns its meaning.

Hong Kong cinema supplies a closer intertext. Chow Yun-fat's Mark in John Woo's *A Better Tomorrow* (1986) — long coat, dark glasses, a pistol in each hand — gave the city's youth a fashion and its cinema the iconography of heroic bloodshed (英雄片), a genre of male loyalty (義) betrayed. The woman in the wig wears Mark's coat and glasses and walks into his genre, but she enters it as a woman without brothers. The genre's codes of fraternity have no place for her, and she is betrayed not by a sworn brother but by an employer. Her masquerade cites genre as well as gender: she wears the costume of a masculine cinema to inhabit a world that offers her no feminine role.

## 3.2 The Colonial Blonde

In Chinese political history, hair is sovereignty. The *Classic of Filial Piety* opens its doctrine with the precept that body, hair, and skin are received from one's parents and must not be harmed: 身體髮膚，受之父母，不敢毀傷，孝之始也. In 1645 the Qing ordered Han men to shave their foreheads and wear the Manchu queue on pain of death — keep the hair and lose the head, or keep the head and lose the hair — so that hair became the visible sign of submission to a new dynasty. After 1911 the queue was cut as a sign of republican modernity. Lu Xun recorded the comedy and pathos of the transition. In "The Story of Hair" (1920), N. cuts his queue while studying in Japan, buys a false one when he returns, is mocked when it is detected, and finally abandons it. In *The True Story of Ah Q* (1921–22), the Qian family's son returns from Japan with his queue cut and a false one attached, and is christened the "Imitation Foreign Devil" (假洋鬼子). Lu Xun had himself cut his queue in Tokyo in 1903.

The woman in the wig is a late heir of the false queue. Her platinum hair is Western hair worn by a Chinese woman in a British colony three years before its transfer. It makes her an imitation foreign devil in the precise sense of Lu Xun's phrase, and in the sense of the Cantonese *gweilo* (鬼佬), "ghost man," the

colony's word for Westerners. Homi Bhabha's "Of Mimicry and Man" (1984) analysed colonial mimicry as the desire for a reformed, recognizable Other who is almost the same but not quite, a resemblance that becomes a menace because it exposes the master's identity as itself a performance. Frantz Fanon's *Black Skin, White Masks* (1952) had anatomized the psychic economy that leads the colonized subject to desire the colonizer's whiteness. The wig is a white mask in Fanon's sense, made literal and made detachable.

Her place in the narcotics trade completes the allegory without requiring it. Hong Kong was ceded to Britain in 1842, at the end of a war Britain waged after the Qing commissioner Lin Zexu confiscated and destroyed the opium stocks of British merchants at Canton in 1839; William Jardine, whose firm was among the largest dealers in the drug, had pressed the Foreign Secretary, Lord Palmerston, to go to war. The colony's great trading houses, Jardine Matheson foremost, rose on opium. Between the foreign firm and the Chinese market stood the comprador (買辦), the Chinese intermediary who managed the firm's local dealings; Robert Ho Tung, Jardine's comprador, became the richest man in the colony. The woman in the wig is a comprador of the illicit economy. She runs a narcotic successor to opium for a Western principal, manages a South Asian labour force, and absorbs the risk when the scheme fails. She stands, in the phrase Rey Chow used for Hong Kong's predicament in the 1990s, between colonizers: in the service of a departing white master, on the threshold of a sovereignty that is not hers.

## 3.3 Tactics of the Weak

Michel de Certeau's *The Practice of Everyday Life* (1980) distinguished strategies, the calculations of subjects with a proper place from which to manage an exterior, from tactics, the manoeuvres of those who have no place of their own and must act within a terrain organized by another. Tactics are, in a formula de Certeau drew from Clausewitz, the art of the weak. They depend on time rather than space, on seizing the opportunity and making do. De Certeau's emblem of the tactic is *la perruque*, "the wig": the worker's own work disguised as work for the employer, such as a secretary's love letter written on company time or a cabinetmaker's furniture turned on the factory lathe. In this film, concept and costume converge with uncanny literalness. The woman in the first episode wears a *perruque*; Faye, in the second, practises *la perruque*, turning her employer's counter, time, and errands to her own designs.

The woman in the wig is a tactician in a world of strategies. She has no proper place and lives in transit, between bar, guesthouse, airport, and hotel. Her disguise follows Sunzi's principle that all warfare is the way of deception (兵者，詭道也). The Thirty-Six Stratagems name the operations of her trade and of her escape: to cross the sea by deceiving the heavens (瞞天過海), the smuggler's art, and to slough the golden cicada's shell (金蟬脫殼), escaping by leaving an empty husk in one's place. Her conspicuousness belongs to the tactic. A platinum blonde in Chungking Mansions is the most visible person in the building, and the wig conceals by exhibition. Her one stated principle — to wear raincoat and dark glasses together, since one never knows whether rain or sun will come — is a doctrine of tactical time. To be prepared for any weather is to abandon the expectation of a forecast. Against 223's hermeneutics of the label, which reads a printed future as fate, her precaution assumes that the future cannot be read at all.

The tactic has its own vulnerability. The couriers she has dressed as respectable travellers vanish at the airport. Her subordinates practise tactics upon her, and she has no strategic place from which to recover the loss. She has been set up by her employer, the strategist whose place — the bar, the network, the Western name — remains intact. The first episode thus stages a chain of tactics, from couriers to smuggler to policeman, beneath a strategist who becomes visible only at the moment of his death.

## 3.4 Behind Dark Glasses

The woman in the wig wears dark glasses at night and indoors. In Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975), classical cinema divides its labour between the man who looks and the woman who is looked at, coded for to-be-looked-at-ness. Dark glasses refuse this division without reversing it. She can be seen but not read; she looks without being seen to look. The close-up of the eyes, cinema's privileged access to interiority, is cancelled. In Sartre's *Being and Nothingness* (1943), the voyeur at the keyhole becomes an object when he hears footsteps and realizes he is seen. Dark glasses are a technology against the look: they let her be seen as an image while withholding the eyes through which another might seize her as a self.

Lacan's eleventh seminar (1964) contains the most famous can in philosophy. As a young intellectual spending time with Breton fishermen, Lacan was shown a sardine can glinting on the waves, and a fisherman called Petit-Jean joked that Lacan could see the can but the can could not see him. Lacan's reflection was

that the joke was not quite true. The can was looking at him, at the point of light from which everything that looks at him is situated, and his unease was that of an intellectual out of place among men who earned their living from the sea and its canneries. For Lacan the gaze belongs not to a subject's eye but to the point of light in the field of the visible. A city of neon is a field of such points. The woman in the wig wears dark glasses at night against a gaze that comes from everywhere, a light that looks back. The can of Chapter Two is the object that looks; the glasses of Chapter Three are the defence against it.

Freud's "Medusa's Head" (1922) read the snake-haired, petrifying face as a figure of castration terror. Hélène Cixous's "The Laugh of the Medusa" (1975) replied that one need only look at the Medusa straight on to see that she is beautiful and laughing. The woman in the wig is a Medusa whose eyes are veiled, Perseus's shield turned around to protect her as much as others. bell hooks's "The Oppositional Gaze" (1992) described the resistant look of Black women spectators who refused the identifications Hollywood offered them; the glasses enact a comparable refusal inside the image. They are also, inescapably, the director's emblem. Wong Kar-wai is rarely photographed without dark glasses, and the smuggler who dresses non-professionals in costume, dispatches them on an improvised mission, and loses them between locations is a figure — irresistible if not demonstrable — of a filmmaker who shot this film in two months, scripting by night, in the interval of another production.

## 3.5 The Star Who Vanishes

The woman in the wig is played by Brigitte Lin Ching-hsia, and the role cannot be separated from her star text in Richard Dyer's sense: the composite image formed by a star's films, publicity, and public life. Lin made her debut in 1973 in *Outside the Window*, an adaptation of Chiung Yao, and through the 1970s she was the face of Taiwanese romantic melodrama. Her Hong Kong career made her an icon of gender crossing. In Tsui Hark's *Peking Opera Blues* (1986) she played a warlord's daughter who dresses as a man to serve the revolution. In *Swordsman II* (1992) she was Dongfang Bubai (東方不敗), the martial master who castrates himself to gain a secret art and becomes a woman, a role that made her an enduring figure for Chinese-language queer audiences. In Ronny Yu's *The Bride with White Hair* (1993), her character's hair turns white when her lover betrays her. In Wong's own *Ashes of Time* (1994), she played Murong Yin and Murong Yang, sister and brother, two faces of one self. In *Chungking Express* she wears platinum hair and is betrayed by her employer. Hair that whitens

with betrayal, and a self divided by gender, pass from role to role. In 1994 Lin married and withdrew from the screen, and the film's last images of her are among the last of her career.

The parallel with Greta Garbo is close. Garbo also played cross-dressing royalty, in *Queen Christina* (1933). Her last film, *Two-Faced Woman* (1941), cast her as a woman impersonating her own twin, and she withdrew from the screen in mid-career and never returned. Roland Barthes's "The Face of Garbo" (1957) distinguished Garbo's face, which was an Idea, from Audrey Hepburn's, which was an Event. Lin's face in *Chungking Express* is neither. It is withheld, its eyes covered, so that one of the star's last roles conceals the face that made her a star.

Agnès Varda's *Cléo from 5 to 7* (1962) is the feminist intertext that makes this concealment legible. Varda's heroine, a pop singer awaiting a medical verdict, lives through chapters stamped to the minute between five o'clock and half past six. At the film's turning point she pulls off her wig, changes into a black dress, and walks into Paris, passing from being looked at to looking; she meets a soldier on leave who must return to the war in Algeria that evening. Varda's film anticipates Wong's in three respects. Its time is dated to the minute; its heroine's liberation is enacted by removing a wig; and its encounter joins a woman awaiting a verdict to a man with a date of departure.

Faye completes the contrast in the second episode. Faye Wong wears her hair cropped short, and her character is the anti-wig, her femininity unadorned and boyish, playful rather than armoured. The two heroines embody the film's two theories of feminine appearance: masquerade as a protective shell, and play as a mode of transformation.

## 3.6 Chungking's Margins

Edward Said's *Culture and Imperialism* (1993) asked that canonical texts be read contrapuntally, together with the colonial geography they presuppose and marginalize — *Mansfield Park* with Antigua in view. *Chungking Express* requires such a reading. The South Asian men whom the woman in the wig recruits as couriers are the first episode's most exploited figures. She dresses them as travellers and loads them with contraband; they speak little; they are pursued; and they vanish. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's "Can the Subaltern Speak?" (1988) argued that the subaltern's speech goes unheard within the discourses that represent her. The couriers' silence belongs to the film.

Their presence in Chungking Mansions is historical, not incidental. Indian troops took part in the British occupation of Hong Kong Island in 1841; Sikh

and Punjabi Muslim policemen were recruited from the 1860s; and Parsi merchants helped found the colony's institutions, one of them starting the ferry service that became the Star Ferry. South Asians are as old as the colony. In 1994 their future was among the most precarious in the territory. Many held a form of British nationality that conferred no right to live in Britain, and they could not acquire Chinese nationality. Only in 1997 did the British Nationality (Hong Kong) Act grant full citizenship to those who would otherwise have been stateless. The couriers' disappearance from the plot is also an image of a population at risk of disappearing from the categories of nationality.

Gordon Mathews's ethnography *Ghetto at the Center of the World* (2011) describes Chungking Mansions as a hub of low-end globalization run by traders from South Asia and Africa. At this point the film's humanism reaches a limit, and dated humanism must name the limit rather than conceal it. The masquerade of the woman in the wig is tactical self-preservation; the couriers' costume is imposed on them. Masquerade is the privilege of those who choose their disguise.

## 3.7 Sealed Off

The first episode culminates in a hotel room. Siegfried Kracauer's essay on the hotel lobby (written 1922–25) described it as the negative image of the church, a space where people are gathered without relation, equal in their emptiness, guests in a place that is no one's home. Simmel's essay "The Adventure" (1911) described the adventure as a fragment of experience cut off from the continuity of life, with a beginning and an end like a dream, in which the incalculable is treated as calculable. 223 and the woman in the wig enter such a room, on the eve of his birthday, as strangers.

Eileen Chang's story "Sealed Off" (1943) supplies the closest literary analogue. A Shanghai tram halts during an air-raid blockade, and time is suspended; two strangers fall into an intimacy that the blockade makes possible and the resumption of traffic dissolves. Her *Love in a Fallen City* (1943) makes the same structure historical. The Japanese conquest of Hong Kong in December 1941 allows two lovers to commit to each other who might otherwise never have done so, and the fall of the city, the narrator reflects, is what completed the heroine. Chang's two stories, set in the two great colonial cities of the China coast, understand love as made possible by the suspension of a city's time. Ann Hui filmed *Love in a Fallen City* in 1984, the year of the Joint Declaration. The hotel room in *Chungking Express* is a sealed-off interval of this

kind, yet nothing happens in it. The woman falls asleep in her clothes; 223 watches television and eats.

The inversion of noir is complete. Where the genre would stage seduction, the film stages sleep. Emmanuel Levinas, in *Existence and Existents* (1947), described sleep as the capacity to withdraw from the anonymous vigilance of being, to lay down one's position; in the presence of another, sleep is total exposure. A woman who has never let down her guard gives up her vigilance in a stranger's presence. Her heels remain on her feet. 223 removes them and polishes them with his tie before he leaves, reasoning that a woman who sleeps in her shoes will wake with swollen feet. This is the film's first act of care, and its grammar matters. He does not touch her; he tends her equipment. His tie, the plainclothes policeman's one emblem of professional dress, becomes a cloth for her shoes, the first movement of the chiasmus of uniforms that Chapter Five will complete.

The shoes are overdetermined. In Mandarin the shoe (鞋 *xié*) puns on 偕 (*xié*), "together," the word of the *Shijing* vow 執子之手，與子偕老: I take your hand; with you I shall grow old. A widespread folk prohibition also holds that one should not give shoes to a lover, lest the lover walk away. 223's attention to her shoes condenses both, the vow of growing old together and the preparation for her departure. European fairy tale adds a third layer. Perrault's "Cinderella," published in 1697 in the same collection as "Bluebeard," turns on a midnight that ends an enchantment and a shoe that identifies the woman who fled. 223's birthday begins at midnight; the second episode's snack bar is called the Midnight Express; and Lau's film of 1995, which parodied Wong's lines, bore the Chinese title of *Cinderella* (仙履奇緣). Yet this prince does not use the shoe to find her. He cleans it and lets her go. Here care is the renunciation of identification.

> *Here care is the renunciation of identification.*

## 3.8 Executing the Master

On 1 May the woman in the wig shoots the Western employer who betrayed her, leaves her wig behind, and sends 223 a birthday greeting on his pager. The date matters. 1 May is International Workers' Day, which commemorates the movement for the eight-hour day — a struggle over who owns the worker's time — and the Chicago events of May 1886. On the day 223's love expires, a

subcontracted worker in a colonial trade executes the boss who exploited and betrayed her.

Hegel's dialectic of lordship and bondage in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807) made the bondsman the bearer of the future: through fear and labour he forms the world and himself, while the lord, dependent on the bondsman's recognition and work, stagnates. Alexandre Kojève's lectures of 1933–39 made this dialectic the motor of history. Fanon objected that the colonial master does not want recognition from the slave; he wants work. Simone de Beauvoir's *The Second Sex* (1949) used the dialectic to describe woman as the Other against whom man defines himself, and argued that one is not born but becomes a woman. The woman in the wig refuses the dialectic's resolution. She does not seek the master's recognition; she kills him and leaves. Audre Lorde's address of 1979 gave feminism a dictum: the master's tools will never dismantle the master's house. The film tests the dictum and partly confirms it. With the master's tools — his gun, his trade, his blondness — she kills the master, but the house stands. The trade continues, the colony continues, and she can only exit. Her emancipation is a departure, not a revolution.

She belongs to a long Chinese lineage of women who kill. Behind Lin's swordswomen stand the Tang tale of Nie Yinniang, the female assassin of the ninth century, and the revolutionary Qiu Jin, who dressed as a man, carried a sword, and was executed by the Qing in 1907. The woman in the wig is their urban successor, but without a cause. Her violence is self-defence in a market rather than righteousness in a cosmos.

Her final acts complete the logic of the wig. She sends 223 a birthday greeting, the film's first gift of a date, from the masquerading woman to a man whose name she may not know. And she leaves the wig behind. The gesture is the golden cicada's escape, the empty shell left in place; it is N.'s abandonment of the false queue; it is Cléo's walk into Paris without her hairpiece. Masquerade ends by exit. It has preserved its wearer through a dated city, but it could not transform that city, and it could give nothing except, at the last, a date. Faye's tactics will be of a different order. She will not disguise herself to survive another's space; she will enter another's space to transform it. The wig conceals a self. The key, the next datum, opens a room.

KEYS
ENCLOSED



Chapter Four

# The Key

*Trespass, Housework, and the Fay in the House*


4.1 The Purloined Keys
4.2 The Traffic in Keys
4.3 *La clef était Fée*
4.4 *Voler*
4.5 The Labour of the Ghost
4.6 The Weeping Room
4.7 The Watcher on the Escalator
4.8 Against Charm

The third datum is a key, and with it the film passes from the defence of a self to the transformation of another's space. The key arrives inside a letter. A departing stewardess leaves an envelope for 663 at the Midnight Express containing the keys to his flat; he declines to collect it; Faye opens it and lets herself in. Through the middle of the second episode she cleans, replaces, restocks, and relabels a home whose tenant believes it has begun to weep. This chapter reads the key through the theory of the purloined letter, the anthropology of exchange, the folklore of forbidden rooms, the feminist critique of housework, and the classical Chinese poetry of the abandoned chamber. Its argument is that Faye's trespass is the film's central figure of the *poetics of relabelling*: an ethics of access that converts another's crypt into a dwelling, and whose legitimacy, uncertain at the moment of entry, is conferred afterward by the time she will give.

## 4.1 The Purloined Keys

In Poe's "The Purloined Letter" (1844), a compromising letter stolen from a royal lady is hidden by the thief in plain sight. The Minister D— turns it inside out like a glove, re-addresses it to himself in a small, feminine hand, seals it with his own cipher, and leaves it soiled in a card-rack, where the police, probing every cavity of his rooms, never think to look. The technique of concealment is relabelling. Dupin recovers the letter by substituting a facsimile, a decoy. Poe's tale already contains the two operations this thesis has distinguished: the reading of surfaces, at which the police fail because they search for depths, and the rewriting of surfaces, at which the thief excels.

Lacan's seminar on the tale (1955), which opens the *Écrits* of 1966, argued that the letter's contents are irrelevant. What matters is its circulation, which assigns positions to whoever holds it, so that each possessor is caught in a structure he does not command and is, in Lacan's term, feminized by possession. The seminar concludes that a letter always arrives at its destination. Derrida's reply, "The Purveyor of Truth" (1975), objected that Lacan's structure depends on a possibility it represses: a letter can always fail to arrive.

The stewardess's letter enters this circuit with precision. Addressed to 663, left with the snack-bar owner, and refused by its addressee for days, it waits at the counter like Poe's letter in its card-rack, visible and unread. 663's refusal is the second policeman's version of the hermeneutics of the label. Where 223 read the date as fate, 663 declines to read in order not to receive the verdict. Faye opens it, and its contents are not words but keys. The signifier that circulates is

an instrument of entry, and whoever holds it acquires not a position in a symbolic structure but the power to open a door. Faye's reading is not interpretation but use; she does not decode the letter's meaning, she operates its contents. Lacan's letter feminizes its possessor; Faye's keys make their possessor a householder.

## 4.2 The Traffic in Keys

Claude Lévi-Strauss's *The Elementary Structures of Kinship* (1949) grounded kinship in the exchange of women between groups of men. Gayle Rubin's "The Traffic in Women" (1975) turned the analysis against itself, arguing that such exchange presupposes a sex/gender system in which women are the gifts and men the partners to the exchange. Luce Irigaray's "Women on the Market" (1977) radicalized the critique: women circulate among men as commodities whose value the male economy sets. Irigaray asked what would happen if the goods refused to go to market and conducted their own commerce among themselves.

The keys in *Chungking Express* travel such a circuit. They pass from a woman, the stewardess, through a man, the owner, who is indifferent to them, past a man, 663, who will not take delivery, into the hands of a woman, Faye. What is exchanged is not a woman but access, and the exchange is completed between women. Irigaray's commodities among themselves become a transaction in keys: the departing woman relinquishes the right of entry and the arriving woman assumes it, without either consulting the man whose home it is.

The key has long been the emblem of a specifically domestic sovereignty. The chatelaine carried the household's keys at her waist; German civil law long called a wife's authority to bind the household in ordinary transactions her *Schlüsselgewalt*, her "power of the keys." In Chinese as in European households, holding the keys meant managing the house (當家). Christian theology knows the *potestas clavium*, the power of the keys given to Peter, which is the power to bind and to loose, to retain and to forgive — a power to which Chapter Six will return through Arendt. The stewardess's return of the keys renounces a domestic sovereignty. Faye's appropriation claims one without marriage, title, or consent; she becomes the keeper of a house that is not hers.

### 4.3 *La clef était Fée*

Charles Perrault's "Bluebeard" (1697) is the European archetype of the forbidden room. A husband gives his new wife all the keys of his house and forbids her one small cabinet; she opens it, finds the bodies of his former wives, and drops the key in their blood. The stain cannot be removed — scrubbed from one side, it reappears on the other — because, Perrault explains, the key was enchanted: *la clef était Fée*. The coincidence of name and enchantment is too exact to pass over. The English name Faye is commonly derived from the archaic *fay*, the fairy, and the heroine of the second episode is, in Perrault's French, a *Fée*. Perrault's key betrays the woman who uses it. Wong's Fée *is* the key, and she does not stain but cleans.

> *"Wong's Fée is the key, and she does not stain but cleans.*

The modern history of the tale reads its forbidden room as a man's interior. Béla Balázs's libretto for Bartók's *Bluebeard's Castle* (1911; first performed 1918) sends Judith through seven doors, onto a torture chamber, an armoury, a treasury, a garden, a domain, a lake of tears, and the former wives. On entering, Judith touches the walls and finds them wet: the castle is weeping. She resolves to dry its walls and warm its stones, and demands that the doors be opened to light and wind. Angela Carter's "The Bloody Chamber" (1979) made the tale feminist by redistributing its agency: the key brands the heroine's forehead with a heart-shaped stain, and it is her mother, not her brothers, who rides to the rescue. Faye is Judith without the castle's terror and Carter's heroine without the murderer. The chamber she opens contains no corpses, only the preserved traces of a departed woman, a crypt in the sense of Chapter Two. Like Judith, she lets in light and dries the weeping walls.

East Asian tradition supplies the inverse type. In the *Soushen houji*, a fifth-century collection attributed to Tao Qian, the orphan Xie Duan keeps a large snail in a jar and returns from his fields each day to find his house cleaned and his meal cooked. Suspecting his neighbours, he leaves at cockcrow, doubles back, and spies through the fence: a young woman emerges from the jar and lights the stove. She is the White Water Maiden (白水素女) of the Heavenly River, sent by the Heavenly Emperor to keep his house for a term of ten years, until he should be prosperous and married. Since he has seen her, she cannot stay. She leaves him her shell as an inexhaustible store for rice and departs amid sudden wind and rain. Hayao Kawai's study of Japanese fairy tales (1982; trans-

lated as *The Japanese Psyche*) contrasted the Bluebeard type, in which a woman's forbidden look is punished, with East Asian tales of the forbidden chamber, the Bush Warbler's Home and the Crane Wife among them, in which a man's look makes the woman vanish and leaves him in an emptiness the tale declines to resolve.

*Chungking Express* fuses both types and departs from both. Like Bluebeard's wife, Faye opens a forbidden room, and her curiosity is not punished. Like the White Water Maiden, she keeps a man's house in secret and vanishes once he has seen her. But her term is set not by a heavenly emperor but by herself, and her vanishing is not an end. The maiden's ten years are cut short by discovery; Faye's single year is chosen, announced, and dated. The fairy's departure in wind and rain will return, transformed, in the rain-smeared boarding pass with which the film ends.

## 4.4 *Voler*

Hélène Cixous's "The Laugh of the Medusa" (1975) built a feminist poetics on a French verb. *Voler* means both to fly and to steal; flying, Cixous wrote, is woman's gesture, and woman takes after both the bird and the thief. Such women pass through, slip away, and delight in scrambling the order of space — disorienting it, moving the furniture, displacing things and values, emptying structures, and turning the proper upside down. It is difficult to imagine a closer description of Faye. She steals a key, rearranges a man's furniture, empties his flat of one woman's traces, and finally flies. *Le propre*, the proper, which Cixous's thieves overturn, also means in French the clean. Faye makes 663's flat *propre*, clean, by violating its *propriété*.

Michel de Certeau's *la perruque*, introduced in Chapter Three, describes the temporal form of Faye's theft. She steals not only access but time, between shifts, from an employer and a city whose schedules are not hers. Her tactics are a trickster's. Hermes, in the Homeric hymn, steals Apollo's cattle on the day of his birth and makes a lyre from a tortoise shell; he becomes the god of thieves, travellers, messengers, and thresholds. Lewis Hyde, in *Trickster Makes This World* (1998), observed that the canonical tricksters of world mythology are overwhelmingly male. Faye answers him: a trickster of thresholds whose thefts are acts of care.

The performer embodies the theme. Faye Wong, born in Beijing in 1969, moved to Hong Kong in 1987 and recorded under a stage name chosen by her label, 王靖雯 (Shirley Wong); around the time of the film she resumed her own

name, 王菲. The star relabelled herself as the character relabels the world. Her Cantonese cover of the Cranberries' "Dreams," discussed in Chapter One, is the same operation in sound: a borrowed melody under a new label.

## 4.5 The Labour of the Ghost

Faye's interventions are, materially, housework: cleaning, laundering, restocking, replacing worn things with new ones. Feminist theory has taught us to see such work. Mariarosa Dalla Costa and Selma James's *The Power of Women and the Subversion of the Community* (1972), and the Wages for Housework campaign launched that year, argued that domestic labour produces the labour-power on which capital depends and that its unwaged status is the mechanism of women's subordination. Silvia Federici's "Wages Against Housework" (1975) compressed the argument into a slogan: what they call love, we call unwaged work. Beauvoir had compared housework to the torment of Sisyphus, cleanliness endlessly soiled and restored; Arlie Hochschild's *The Second Shift* (1989) documented the second working day that awaited employed women at home.

Faye's housework satisfies every term of this critique and inverts its meaning. It is unwaged, invisible, and performed for love; it is a second shift, worked around her shifts at the counter. Yet it is neither assigned nor expected, and it is not maintenance. Beauvoir's Sisyphus restores a household to its prior state; Faye transforms one into something its tenant has never seen. Her labour is authorship rather than reproduction, play rather than duty. It is housework turned into *la perruque*: the form of domestic service used for her own ends.

Chantal Akerman's cinema provides the decisive comparison. In *Jeanne Dielman, 23 quai du Commerce, 1080 Bruxelles* (1975), which *Sight and Sound*'s critics' poll of 2022 named the greatest film ever made, a widow's domestic routine is filmed over three days in near real time; when the routine falters, the film ends in a killing. Housework there is a clock, and its breakdown is catastrophe. In Akerman's earlier *Je tu il elle* (1974), a young woman alone in a room repeatedly rearranges her furniture, eats sugar from a bag, and writes letters, before leaving in search of others. Faye belongs to the second Akerman, not the first. Her housework breaks the clock instead of serving it, and her rearrangement of furniture is a self-invention that ends, as Julie's does, in departure.

Sara Ahmed's *Queer Phenomenology* (2006) read the philosopher's writing table, in Husserl, as an object that orients thought only because the domestic labour around it has been relegated to the background: someone else does the housework so that the philosopher may face his table. 663 is such a figure. He

notices not the labour performed in his home but only its effects, which he reads as the moods of his possessions. To him the work has no worker. It is the labour of a ghost — the condition, feminist theory insists, of all housework. Virginia Woolf told women writers in "Professions for Women" (1931) that they must kill the Angel in the House, the self-effacing domestic ideal. Faye is not an angel but a ghost, and her haunting rearranges the house rather than sustaining it.

Contrapuntal reading must also name the labour the film omits. By the mid-1990s well over a hundred thousand foreign domestic workers, most of them Filipinas, lived in Hong Kong households, and on Sundays they gathered in Central, a few streets from the Midnight Express. Nicole Constable's *Maid to Order in Hong Kong* (1997) and Rhacel Salazar Parreñas's *Servants of Globalization* (2001) documented the regime of contracts, residence rules, and surveillance under which they kept other people's homes; Hochschild later named the structure a global care chain. Faye's housework, chosen and romantic, is the fantasy image of a labour that in the Central of 1994 was waged, compulsory, and unseen. Here, as with the couriers, the film's humanism reaches a limit that dated humanism must name.

Xi Xi's story "A Woman Like Me" (1982) supplies a last Hong Kong counter-image. Its narrator is a cosmetician of the dead, whose hidden labour makes the departed presentable to the living, and who expects to be abandoned by any man who learns her trade. Faye's work in 663's flat is also a cosmetics of the departed, the tidying of a crypt. But it is undertaken to make a dwelling livable again rather than to make the dead presentable.

## 4.6 The Weeping Room

663 does not detect the intrusion. He talks to his things. He tells a shrinking bar of soap that it has lost weight and should have more confidence; he tells a sodden towel to stop crying; and when water appears where it should not, he concludes that the flat itself is weeping, reflecting that he once believed a bar of soap was only soap and a towel only a towel, until she left. The policeman's forensic habit fails at home. Where 223 measured, 663 empathizes, and evidence of intrusion becomes, for him, evidence of feeling.

John Ruskin, in the third volume of *Modern Painters* (1856), named this projection the pathetic fallacy: the false appearance that emotion lends to things, as when a poet calls the foam cruel. Wang Guowei, in his *Renjian cihua* (人間詞話, 1908–09), dignified it as a realm of poetry. In the realm that contains the self (有

我之境), he wrote, one views things through the self, so that all things bear the self's colouring: 以我觀物，故物皆著我之色彩. His two examples are a boudoir and an inn. A woman in a deep courtyard asks the flowers through her tears, and the flowers say nothing as the scattered petals fly past the swing (淚眼問花花不語，亂紅飛過秋千去). A traveller is shut in a lonely inn with the cold of spring (可堪孤館閉春寒). The hotel room of the first episode and the abandoned flat of the second are Wang Guowei's two rooms.

Wang's first example belongs to the boudoir lament (閨怨), the genre in which a woman left at home mourns a man who has gone away. Wang Changling's quatrain of that title gives the classic form: a young wife who knows no sorrow climbs her tower on a spring day, sees the willows greening by the road, and suddenly regrets having sent her husband off to seek a noble title (悔教夫婿覓封侯). The genre was largely written by men in a woman's voice, and from Qu Yuan's *Lisao* onward the tradition of fragrant herbs and fair women (香草美人) read the abandoned woman as the neglected minister and the departed beloved as the sovereign. *Chungking Express* removes the ventriloquism. Its abandoned lover is a man speaking in his own voice from his own chamber, while the woman who left has gone to pursue her career in the sky. Lauren Berlant's *The Female Complaint* (2008) described the intimate public formed around women's narratives of love's disappointment; 663 performs the female complaint without a public, addressing his soap. The political allegory that the tradition invites, a colony as the abandoned partner of a departing sovereign, the film permits but does not require.

Freud's "The Uncanny" (1919) observed that the German *heimlich* means both "homely" and "secret," and that in its semantic development the word converges with its opposite, *unheimlich*. Faye is the secret (*heimlich*) presence in the home (*Heim*), and her secret makes the familiar strange. Gaston Bachelard's *The Poetics of Space* (1957) described the house as the shelter of daydreaming and gave a chapter to shells, the dwellings from which creatures emerge. The White Water Maiden came from a shell; Faye, too, emerges from the house's own hiding places. Sara Ahmed's *The Cultural Politics of Emotion* (2004) described emotions as sticky, adhering to objects through histories of contact. 663's soap and towel are sticky with the departed stewardess. By replacing them, Faye unsticks his grief. The new soap has no history, and the flat begins, without his knowledge, to belong to the present.

## 4.7 The Watcher on the Escalator

Faye's first approach to 663's flat is visual. Riding the Mid-Levels Escalator uphill, she looks into his window. The scene inverts Hitchcock's *Rear Window* (1954), in which an immobilized man watches his neighbours from his flat while Lisa, his fiancée, enters a suspect's apartment in search of evidence. In Wong's film the watcher and the trespasser are the same woman, and the watched man is guilty of nothing but grief. The escalator itself, scheduled to run downhill for the morning rush and uphill for the rest of the day, carries her through the city's off-peak hours, its tactical time.

Laura Mulvey's account of the male gaze was answered in feminist film theory by attempts to describe a look that does not master. Kaja Silverman's *The Threshold of the Visible World* (1996) proposed the productive look, which confers ideality on what the dominant visual order devalues: a look that gives rather than takes. Faye's look is of this kind. She sees a grieving beat policeman and sees him as worth transforming. Her gaze does not fix him as an object of knowledge, as 223's forensic voice-over fixes its women in hours and centimetres; it sees what his flat might become.

## 4.8 Against Charm

Faye's charm has made her an emblem of what later criticism would call the manic pixie dream girl, a term Nathan Rabin coined in 2007 for the whimsical young woman who exists to teach a brooding man to embrace life. The film resists the type. The dream girl serves the man's growth; Faye has her own dream, leaves to pursue it, and declines to keep the date that would have made her his reward. Her genealogy is Godardian rather than Hollywood: Jean Seberg's Patricia in *Breathless* (1960), crop-haired, American, hawking newspapers on the Champs-Élysées and finally turning a man over to the police, and Anna Karina's Odile dancing the Madison in *Bande à part* (1964). Faye inverts Patricia as she inverts Bluebeard's wife. Rather than delivering a man to the police, she trespasses on a policeman.

Sianne Ngai's *Our Aesthetic Categories* (2012) gives the charm a political economy. The cute, Ngai argues, is the aesthetic of small, helpless commodities that invite both tenderness and aggression; the zany is the aesthetic of strenuous, precarious performance, of affective labour that cannot stop working. Faye at the counter, dancing to her tape and serving customers to music played at full

volume, is zany in Ngai's sense. Her charm is labour, and the film shows that labour turned to her own account.

The ethics of the trespass remain. Faye enters a man's home without his knowledge. Kant's *Toward Perpetual Peace* (1795) limited cosmopolitan hospitality to a right of visit, not a right of residence. Derrida's *Of Hospitality* (1997) argued that unconditional hospitality must welcome the newcomer without asking her name, and that hospitality is shadowed by its etymological twin, hostility. Faye is the guest who becomes host in another's house, keeping it for him without invitation.

Tsai Ming-liang's *Vive L'Amour*, released the same year, stages the darkest version of this trespass. Hsiao-kang, a young man who sells niches in a columbarium, finds a key left in the door of an empty luxury flat, takes it, and lives there in secret; soon after entering, he attempts suicide in the flat and survives. The flat is then used for trysts by May, the estate agent trying to sell it, and a street vendor, while Hsiao-kang hides beneath the bed. Tsai's stolen key admits a man to an empty space in order to die in it, and his trespass produces only adjacent solitudes; Faye's admits her to an occupied space in order to make it livable. The two films of 1994 that lent the numeral of ten thousand years to love divide trespass between its two possibilities: the taken key as an instrument of despair and as an instrument of care.

Chinese romance has long known this ambiguity. In Yuan Zhen's "Tale of Yingying" (c. 804), the source of *The Romance of the Western Chamber*, Yingying sends Zhang a poem: waiting for the moon beneath the western chamber, the door half open to the breeze; the flowers' shadows stir along the wall, as if her beloved were coming (待月西廂下，迎風戶半開。拂牆花影動，疑是玉人來). Zhang climbs the wall and is sternly rebuked; days later Yingying comes to him of her own accord. The half-open door is both invitation and test, and the right of entry is established only afterward, by the one entered upon.

The film resolves Faye's trespass the same way, but across a year. When 663 at last discovers her, he does not arrest her; soon afterward he asks her on a date. Retrospective consent converts intrusion into invitation. Faye then withdraws. By failing to keep the date and leaving for a year, she gives his consent time to become free rather than grateful, surprised, or obliged. The year restores the symmetry the trespass broke, and when she returns it is he who places himself in her hands. The key opened a room. The pass, the final datum, will open the world.

SAME DAY
NEXT YEAR



Chapter Five

# The Pass

*Flight, Return, and the Gift of the Date*

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5.1 The Missed Rendezvous
5.2 A Counterfeit Pass
5.3 The Feather Robe
5.4 After Nora Leaves
5.5 The Chiasmus of Uniforms
5.6 Destinerrance

The fourth datum is a document of passage that is also a forgery and a gift. Asked on a date, Faye does not come. She flies to California and leaves 663 a boarding pass she has drawn on a paper napkin, dated one year ahead. A year later she returns in the uniform of a flight attendant to the snack bar he now owns. The pass, rained on, has lost its legibility; she offers to write him another and asks where he would like to go, and he answers that he will go wherever she wants to take him. This chapter reads the pass as the culmination of the film's argument: the conversion of the expiry date into a date given. It moves through the cinema of the missed rendezvous, the philosophy of the gift, the swan-maiden tales of East Asia, the Chinese debate over what happens after Nora leaves home, and the gendered economy of the uniform. It ends with the chiasmus in which the film's two modalities of time exchange places.

## 5.1 The Missed Rendezvous

663 waits at a bar called California while Faye is on her way to California. The pun is the episode's hinge. The bar was a real establishment in Lan Kwai Fong, and the state was, for the Hong Kong of 1994, a real destination of emigration. The film lets one place name designate both a local appointment and a transpacific departure, so that missing the date and leaving the city become the same act.

European art cinema had made the missed rendezvous a form. Antonioni's *L'Eclisse* (1962) ends when its lovers agree to meet at eight, at the usual place, and neither comes; for seven minutes the camera records the street corner, the crossing, the water barrel, and the lamps as the city goes on without them. Jacques Demy's *The Umbrellas of Cherbourg* (1964) divides its story into dated parts — the departure, the absence, the return — as a young mechanic is called up for the war in Algeria and the woman who loves him cannot wait. In the epilogue, on a snowy Christmas Eve, she pulls into the petrol station he now owns, and they part. Hollywood knew the type as melodrama. In Leo McCarey's *An Affair to Remember* (1957), lovers agree to meet atop the Empire State Building in six months, and the woman, struck by a car on her way, does not come.

*Chungking Express* takes Demy's structure and reverses its outcome. Its second episode is also a story of departure, absence, and return, dated by its own boarding pass, and its coda also stages a woman's arrival at the small business the man has acquired in her absence. But Demy's couple part, and Wong's may leave together. Antonioni's lovers miss each other through an indifference the film declines to explain; Faye misses the date by choice and leaves an expla-

nation in the form of a date. The rendezvous is not cancelled but postponed, and the postponement is given as a gift.

Xi Xi's "A Woman Like Me," introduced in Chapter Four, ends in a café where a woman waits for a man she expects to lose. *Chungking Express* reverses the scene. Here the man waits, and the woman, who has found work, does not come.

## 5.2 A Counterfeit Pass

The pass is a forgery. It is drawn by hand on a napkin from the snack bar, it bears no airline's authority, and it admits no one to any aircraft. Baudelaire's prose poem "Counterfeit Money," collected in *Paris Spleen* (1869), tells of a man who gives a beggar a counterfeit coin and congratulates himself at once on his charity and his economy. The narrator, appalled, imagines the coin's possible futures: it might be passed on and multiply into real wealth, or land the beggar in prison. Derrida's *Given Time* (1991) made the poem the occasion for a theory of the gift. A gift, Derrida argued, is annulled the moment it is recognized as a gift, since recognition calls for gratitude, and gratitude is a return that closes the circle of exchange. The gift is impossible within economy and yet is what sets economy in motion, and it requires time: the counter-gift must be deferred, or what was given becomes merely traded. The gift, in Derrida's phrase, gives time.

Marcel Mauss's *The Gift* (1925) had observed that every gift implies a term, a delay before the return, and that the notion of credit is born in this interval. Faye's pass is the gift of a term. It gives 663 a date one year ahead, and the year is the gift's content: the time in which he may change, choose, or forget. It is counterfeit in exactly Baudelaire's sense, paper that is not money, and like the coin in the narrator's speculation it may generate real value if it is passed on and honoured. The film honours it.

The pass is also a promise. The second essay of Nietzsche's *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887) opens by asking how one might breed an animal with the right to make promises, an animal with a memory of the will, able to stand surety for its own future. Faye stands surety for a self a year away. In a city whose future had been promised by treaty — fifty years without change — and whose documents of passage were themselves equivocal, the counterfeit pass is a sharper object than it seems. From 1987 the British National (Overseas) passport gave Hong Kong's British Dependent Territories citizens a nationality with-

out a right of abode in the United Kingdom: a pass without a destination. Faye's pass inverts it. It has no authority, but it has a fixed return.

The snack bar from which the napkin comes shares its name with Alan Parker's *Midnight Express* (1978), the film of an American smuggler imprisoned in Turkey, in whose prison argot to catch the midnight express meant to escape. Whether or not the real establishment intended the allusion, the film's counter is named for flight.

## 5.3 The Feather Robe

The oldest written version of the swan-maiden tale is generally traced to Gan Bao's *Soushen ji* of the fourth century. A man of Yuzhang sees six or seven women in a field, all wearing feather robes; he steals the robe of one, the others fly away, and the one who cannot fly becomes his wife and bears him three daughters. Years later she has a daughter ask the father where the robe is hidden, finds it beneath the rice stacks, puts it on, and flies away; afterward she returns for her daughters, and they fly away too. China's most enduring love story has the same structure. The Cowherd hides the robe of a celestial Weaver Girl bathing on earth and marries her; she is taken back to heaven, a river of stars is drawn between them, and they may meet only once a year, on the seventh night of the seventh month, on a bridge of magpies.

The Weaver Girl's story is the paradigmatic Chinese romance of the date. Qin Guan's lyric "Immortal at the Magpie Bridge" (鵲橋仙) gives its philosophy. One meeting of golden wind and jade dew surpasses countless meetings in the human world (金風玉露一相逢，便勝卻人間無數); tenderness is like water, and the appointed date like a dream (柔情似水，佳期如夢); and if the love of two endures, what need is there to be together morning and evening (兩情若是久長時，又豈在朝朝暮暮)? The poem answers in advance the revolutionary urgency recalled in Chapter Two, which would seize every morning and evening. Qin Guan's lovers need one dated night a year. Faye's year away is a Weaver Girl's year, and her return is a Double Seventh.

The Noh play *Hagoromo* turns the tale toward ethics. A fisherman finds a celestial maiden's feather robe on a pine at Miho and will return it only if she dances for him; she replies that without the robe she cannot dance. He fears that if he gives it first she will fly away without dancing. She answers that doubt belongs to mortals, and that in heaven there is no deceit. He returns the robe, and she dances before ascending. The fisherman must give first and trust that the gift will be answered.

*Chungking Express* rewrites the tale-type at every point. No man steals Faye's robe; she acquires it herself, as a uniform earned through employment, and it signifies not her captivity but her mobility. At the end 663 does not hold her robe hostage. Like the fisherman of Miho, he gives first: his trust, and the choice of destination. The feather robe is also, in the modern economy, a uniform of service. Arlie Hochschild's *The Managed Heart* (1983), a study of Delta Air Lines' flight attendants, coined the term *emotional labour* for the work of producing a feeling in others by managing one's own, and showed how the airline trained its workers to smile as if they meant it. The flight attendant is the modern feather-robed woman: mobile, celestial, and at work. Faye's wings are a job.

> *Faye's wings are a job.*

## 5.4 After Nora Leaves

Ibsen's *A Doll's House* (1879) ends with Nora changing out of her masquerade costume, handing back her wedding ring and the household keys, and leaving her husband's house. The stewardess who leaves 663 performs Nora's gestures: she returns his keys and goes. After *New Youth* devoted an issue to Ibsen in 1918, the play became a founding text of women's emancipation in China, and in a lecture of 1923 at the Beijing Women's Normal College Lu Xun asked what happens after Nora leaves. His answer was economic. Without means of her own, he argued, Nora has only two paths, to fall or to come back, and he stated the principle that would discipline the dream of liberation: dreams are good, but otherwise money is essential (夢是好的；否則，錢是要緊的). The same lecture contains the sentence chosen as this thesis's epigraph: the most painful thing in life is to wake from a dream and find no road to walk.

Lu Xun dramatized the darker path in "Regret for the Past" (傷逝, 1925). Zijun leaves her family for love, declaring that she belongs to herself and that no one has the right to interfere with her (我是我自己的，他們誰也沒有干涉我的權利！); poverty follows, her lover tells her he no longer loves her, and she returns home and dies. The story is narrated by the man as a lament for a departed woman, and its form is the form of 223's and 663's voice-overs. Eileen Chang's essay "Go! Go Upstairs" (1944) gave the Nora question its Shanghai answer: Chinese youth learned the gesture of leaving home from Ibsen, but with nowhere to go, leaving often meant going upstairs. Faye, who first ascends the

Mid-Levels by escalator and enters a man's flat, has gone upstairs. Then she goes higher.

Faye's answer to Lu Xun is a job. She leaves not on a dream alone but on a wage, as a flight attendant in the service economy. Beauvoir's chapter on the independent woman in *The Second Sex* made economic independence the precondition of women's freedom, while insisting that the working woman still bears the costs of femininity; Hochschild's analysis shows that the airline sells precisely those costs. Lauren Berlant's *Cruel Optimism* (2011) described attachments to fantasies of the good life that obstruct the flourishing they promise. Faye's California, announced by a song from 1965 played to exhaustion, might have been such an attachment. The film tests the possibility and refuses it: the dream is dated, financed, travelled, and returned from.

The departure belongs to its moment. In the early 1990s roughly sixty thousand people a year left Hong Kong for Canada, Australia, and the United States. Cantonese coined the word *taikongren* (太空人), "astronaut," for the husband who stayed to work in Hong Kong while his family settled abroad, a pun on a wife (太太) whose absence leaves the home empty (空). 663 is an astronaut in reverse: his woman flies, and he keeps the empty flat. Clara Law's *Autumn Moon* (1992), winner of the Golden Leopard at Locarno, told of a fifteen-year-old girl whose family had emigrated to Canada while she waited with her grandmother. Xi Xi's *Marvels of a Floating City* (1986) imagined Hong Kong as a city suspended between sky and sea, its inhabitants unsure whether it would rise or fall. Faye's return after a year anticipates the return wave (回流) of the later 1990s, when emigrants who had secured foreign passports came back. The film's figure of emancipation is not exile but circulation.

Beauvoir's *The Ethics of Ambiguity* (1947) held that to will oneself free is also to will others free. Faye's freedom takes this form. Her departure leaves 663 free, and her return asks him to choose freely.

## 5.5 The Chiasmus of Uniforms

The coda is constructed as a crossing. At the start of the second episode, 663 wears the uniform of the Royal Hong Kong Police and buys chef's salads at the Midnight Express counter for a stewardess, while Faye stands behind the counter in a snack-bar worker's clothes. In the coda, 663 has left the police and bought the snack bar, and he stands behind the counter out of uniform. Faye arrives in a flight attendant's uniform. The man takes the counter; the woman

takes the sky. This is the *chiasmus of care*: the one who was served now serves, and the one who served now asks where he would like to be taken.

663's uniform was itself dated. The force had been granted the title "Royal" in 1969 in recognition of its conduct during the disturbances of 1967, the year of the pineapples, and the crown on its badge was due to disappear on 1 July 1997. In leaving the police, 663 sheds a uniform that would in any case have expired. Faye's uniform repeats that of the stewardess, the woman who left him, and Kierkegaard's distinction from Chapter Two decides its meaning. Recollection would have made Faye a copy of the departed woman, a garment one has outgrown. Repetition makes the uniform an indestructible garment, new because it is taken up forward. Judith Butler's *Gender Trouble* located agency not in escaping repetition but in repeating otherwise, in the variation that opens within a citation. Faye cites the stewardess's role and varies it.

Hochschild's analysis returns here with full force. A flight attendant's work consists of questions — what would you like, may I take that, where are you headed — asked with managed warmth. Faye's question in the coda, where he would like to go, is the professional question of her trade. Spoken off duty to a man behind a counter, it becomes a lover's question, and 663's answer, wherever she wants to take him, returns the question as a gift. The language of service becomes the language of care, and the chiasmus passes through the very words that the economy of emotional labour scripts.

Merleau-Ponty's unfinished *The Visible and the Invisible* (1964) described the chiasm, the reversibility of seeing and being seen, touching and being touched, as the structure of the flesh. The film's chiasmus is a reversibility of serving and being served. Its Chinese name was given in Chapter One: 交, the crossed legs of the *Shuowen*, the handing over (交給), the exchange (交換), the handover (交接). In the year the film was made, the city's handover was a transfer between sovereigns in which its people had little say. In the coda, the handover is between persons, and each hands the other the power to decide.

## 5.6 Destinerrance

Lacan ended his seminar on Poe by declaring that a letter always arrives at its destination. Derrida answered that it can always fail to arrive and coined *destinerrance* for the errancy that inhabits every sending. Barbara Johnson's "The Frame of Reference" (1977) offered a resolution that serves this film exactly: a letter's destination is wherever it is read, the place it assigns to its reader as his own.

Faye's pass arrives, but its destination has been lost. Kept through a year, it has been soaked by rain and its ink has run. The smear recalls the step-printed crowd of Chapter One and the flying white of the calligrapher's dry brush, and it recalls the White Water Maiden, who left amid sudden wind and rain. The pass has arrived at the place where it is read, and that place is the counter at which its author stands. Its destination is illegible, and the illegibility is the film's last gift. Faye offers to write another pass and asks where he wants to go; 663 answers that he will go wherever she wants to take him. Destination is surrendered to the other, and destinerrance becomes trust.

> *Destination is surrendered to the other, and destinerrance becomes trust.*

The film's closing song, Faye Wong's "Dreams" (夢中人, "the person in the dream"), invites a final juxtaposition. In the *Zhuangzi*, Zhuang Zhou dreams that he is a butterfly, flitting happily and unaware of being Zhou. Waking, he cannot tell whether he is Zhou who dreamed of being a butterfly or a butterfly dreaming that it is Zhou. Between them, the text concludes, there must be a distinction, and this is called the transformation of things: 此之謂物化. In modern Chinese, 物化 is also the standard translation of Lukács's *reification*. The film begins in one sense of the word and ends in the other. 223's tins are reification: time made a thing, love sealed in tin. Faye's pass is transformation: a thing that remakes the persons between whom it passes. The final chapter draws out what this passage from reification to transformation implies for a humanism adequate to a dated world.

Chapter Six

# Toward a Dated Humanism


6.1 From Man's Expiry to the Human's Date
6.2 Four Data, Four Temporal Ethics
6.3 The Counter as World
6.4 Promise and Forgiveness
6.5 Fragility and Precarity
6.6 Feminism's Flight, Humanism's Return
6.7 Coda: The Film's Own Expiry




The preceding chapters have read four objects as four technologies of time. This chapter assembles them into a theory. Its claim is that *Chungking Express* articulates a humanism that comes after the anti-humanist critique of "man": a humanism that restores no timeless human essence but locates the human in the capacity to date — to receive a dated world, to survive it, to enter another's time, and to give time away. The chapter situates this claim in the history of humanism's expiry, derives four temporal ethics from the four data, and tests the resulting theory against Arendt, Confucian *ren*, Nussbaum, Butler, Wynter, Said, and feminist philosophies of time and care. It closes with the film's own expiry.

## 6.1 From Man's Expiry to the Human's Date

Foucault's *The Order of Things* (1966) ends by proposing that man is an invention of recent date, perhaps nearing its end, who may be effaced like a face traced in sand where the tide comes in. Foucault's own word was *date*: the archaeology of thought, he wrote, shows man's recent date and perhaps his near end. The image became the emblem of an anti-humanist decade. Sartre had lectured in 1945 that existentialism is a humanism; Heidegger's "Letter on Humanism" (1947) replied that every humanism rests on an unexamined metaphysics of man. Lévi-Strauss wrote in *The Savage Mind* (1962) that the aim of the human sciences was not to constitute man but to dissolve him; Althusser's *For Marx* (1965) proclaimed a theoretical anti-humanism; and Derrida's "The Ends of Man" (1968) played on *end* as both terminus and purpose. By the 1990s, "man" had acquired, in theory, an expiry date.

The question was not only European. Across the border, in 1983, Zhou Yang and Wang Ruoshui argued for a Marxist humanism able to recognize alienation (異化) under socialism. The Party leadership condemned the position in the campaign against "spiritual pollution" launched that autumn: Hu Qiaomu, the Politburo's chief ideologist, published the official rebuttal in January 1984; Zhou Yang was pressed into a public self-criticism; and Wang Ruoshui was removed as deputy editor-in-chief of the *People's Daily* and pushed out of the Party in 1987. In Hong Kong itself a Confucian humanism (人文主義) had been rebuilt in exile. Tang Junyi, Mou Zongsan, and their colleagues at New Asia College, founded in Kowloon in 1949, issued in 1958 a manifesto to the world on behalf of Chinese culture. Tang's essay of 1961 on the "withering and scattering of the flowers and fruits" (花果飄零) of the Chinese people lamented a dispersed civilization, and a sequel urged that its spiritual roots be replanted (靈根自植)

wherever its people found themselves. Hong Kong was a city in which humanism was at once a heresy next door and a project of cultural survival at home.

*Chungking Express* answers by neither restoring man nor dissolving him. It proposes the human as the being that dates. Its last image answers Foucault's. Foucault's face in the sand is erased by water; Faye's pass, written in ink, is smeared by rain. But the film does not end with the erasure: Faye offers to write the pass again. Against Tang Junyi's humanism of roots, the film offers a humanism of circulation; against Foucault's erasure, a humanism of re-inscription. It accepts that every human mark expires and locates dignity in the capacity to mark again, for another.

The humanism is dated in four registers, and they form a structure rather than a pun. It is *inscribed with dates*: the human is the being that marks, keeps, and breaks time, and is marked in turn by birth, death, deadline, and anniversary. It is *historically superseded*: it comes after Man and claims no exemption from history. It is *given*: its paradigmatic act is the gift of time, as the Latin *data* recorded a letter's giving. And it is *amorous*: its scene is the appointment, kept or missed. Each register entails the others. A being inscribed with dates can give them; a being historically superseded must find its dignity in the use of finite time rather than in permanence; a being that has been given time can give it; and the appointment is where such giving takes place.

## 6.2 Four Data, Four Temporal Ethics

The four data can now be set side by side.

| Datum | Holder | Operation on time | Temporal mode | Ethic | Failure mode |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Can | 223 | Conservation: time sealed, portioned, and dated | Recollection | Fidelity to what has been | The crypt: mourning refused |
| Wig | The woman in the blonde wig | Masquerade: a self preserved through a dated city | Precaution | Self-preservation | Exit without transformation |
| Key | Faye | Trespass: another's time entered and remade | Opportunity (*kairos*) | Care before consent | Intrusion |
| Pass | Faye, then 663 | Promise: time given in advance | Repetition | The gift of a date | A counterfeit never honoured |

The sequence runs from keeping time to giving time. The can and the pass are its poles: the one seals time against its passage, the other gives time before it arrives. Between them, the wig and the key mark two feminine tactics: disguise,

which preserves a self within another's order, and trespass, which transforms another's order from within. The sequence is not a progress from error to truth. Each datum has its own dignity — the can's fidelity, the wig's courage, the key's care — but only the pass crosses between the sexes and returns, rewritten at the end by the hand that first wrote it.

The two episodes are thus two humanisms. The first, in which a policeman keeps tins and a smuggler keeps a disguise, answers the dated world by preservation: it reads the label and holds what it can. The second, in which a countergirl relabels a flat and forges a pass, answers it by transformation: it rewrites the given. The *hermeneutics of the label* and the *poetics of relabelling* are in this light not merely gendered styles but the two classic postures of humanism itself, the philological and the poetic: the humanism that conserves a tradition and the humanism that remakes it. The coda joins them. The man of the label surrenders destination; the woman of relabelling writes a new pass.

Aristotle defined the human as the animal possessing *logos*; Nietzsche asked how an animal might earn the right to promise; Heidegger defined Dasein by its being toward death. The film's implicit definition is that the human is the animal that gives dates — that can receive the expiry printed on things, survive it, and convert it into time given to another. Kant placed dignity in what is above all price and admits no equivalent. The film relocates it. Dignity lies not in exemption from expiry but in the use made of finite time for another.

> *Dignity lies not in exemption from expiry but in the use made of finite time for another.*

## 6.3 The Counter as World

In *The Human Condition* (1958), Hannah Arendt described the world as the in-between of human affairs, a table set between those who sit around it, which relates and separates them at once. Mass society, she wrote, resembles a séance at which the table suddenly vanishes, leaving those who sat opposite one another no longer separated but also no longer related by anything tangible. The Midnight Express counter is the film's table. It is the only place the two episodes share; it relates and separates customers and workers; and across it pass food, money, letters, keys, glances, and a pass. Chapter One called it a non-place in Augé's sense and a threshold in Bakhtin's. The film's achievement is to make the non-place a world.

Confucian thought names the relation that the counter houses. The *Shuowen jiezi* glosses 仁 as intimacy (親) and analyses the graph into 人, person, and 二, two. The *Zhongyong* states that *ren* is the human (仁者人也), and Zheng Xuan's Han commentary reads the phrase through an idiom of persons as mutual counterparts (相人偶), each attending to the other. Mencius repeats that *ren* is what it is to be human; the *Analects* define it as loving others (愛人) and as establishing others in wishing to establish oneself (己欲立而立人). *Ren* is the humanity that exists only between two.

In its classical setting, *ren* radiates through kinship. Fei Xiaotong's *From the Soil* (1948) described Chinese social relations as ripples spreading from a stone dropped in water, each circle weaker than the last, with the self at the centre. The counter replaces the ripple. Its relations do not radiate from kin; they form between strangers across a surface and are converted into intimacy by time. *Chungking Express* thereby gives Confucian humanism an urban, non-familial, transactional site: *ren* between strangers at a counter. Sara Ahmed's reading of the philosopher's table, discussed in Chapter Four, sharpens the point. The writing table orients thought by hiding the labour that sustains it; the counter is a table at which service is performed in full view. In the coda the counter changes hands, from the owner to 663: a world handed over (交) between persons.

## 6.4 Promise and Forgiveness

Arendt identified two faculties by which action is redeemed from its own predicaments. Against irreversibility, the inability to undo what has been done, stands forgiveness; against unpredictability, the opacity of the future, stands the promise. She called trespassing an everyday occurrence, inherent in action's constant creation of new relationships, and argued that it must be forgiven so that life can go on — language that echoes the old English prayer, *forgive us our trespasses, as we forgive them that trespass against us*. The alternative to forgiveness is vengeance, the automatic reaction that binds both parties to the original deed.

The diptych enacts Arendt's alternatives. The first episode ends in vengeance: the woman in the wig executes the master who betrayed her, the act binds her, and she can only vanish. The second ends in forgiveness. 663, a policeman whose profession is to hold trespasses against their authors, looses Faye's: he does not arrest her but invites her. Chapter Four recalled that the *potestas clavium*, the power of the keys, is the power to bind and to loose. Faye takes the keys; 663 exercises their power. Confucian ethics names a kindred virtue. Asked

for a single word to guide a whole life, Confucius proposed 恕, reciprocity — not to impose on others what one does not desire oneself (己所不欲，勿施於人) — and in modern Chinese the same character means to forgive.

The promise answers unpredictability. Faye's pass is a promise in Arendt's sense, an island of predictability in an ocean of uncertainty, dated a year ahead. The literary annuals of the nineteenth century, published in autumn and dated for the year to come, were made to be given; Poe's "The Purloined Letter" first appeared in one of them, titled *The Gift* and dated 1845. Faye's pass belongs to this tradition of gifts dated ahead.

Arendt's deepest answer to Heidegger was natality: human beings, though they must die, are born not in order to die but in order to begin. The film's central date stages this answer with startling economy. 1 May is the expiry date stamped on 223's tins, and it is his birthday. The date of ending is the date of beginning; every expiry date is someone's birthday. The film's first gift of a date is a birthday greeting, sent by the woman of vengeance on the morning of her killing. Forgiveness releases the past from its date; promise dates the future; natality makes every date a possible beginning. Dated humanism is the humanism that holds these three powers together.

> *Every expiry date is someone's birthday.*

## 6.5 Fragility and Precarity

Martha Nussbaum's *The Fragility of Goodness* (1986) took as its emblem Pindar's eighth Nemean ode, which likens human excellence to a vine that grows on dew. Against the philosophical ambition to make the good life invulnerable to luck, Nussbaum defended the tragic recognition that the most valuable goods — love, friendship, political life — are by their nature exposed to fortune. 223's tins are a Platonic strategy in Nussbaum's sense, an attempt to make love invulnerable by scheduling it; Faye accepts exposure. In *Women and Human Development* (2000), Nussbaum listed among the central human capabilities emotion, affiliation, play, and control over one's environment. Faye exercises play and control over an environment; 663 recovers emotion and affiliation. Dated humanism adds a temporal clause: capabilities are exercised in time, and the capability to give time is among them.

Judith Butler's *Precarious Life* (2004) and *Frames of War* (2009) located a common human condition in bodily vulnerability, while showing that grievabil-

ity is unequally distributed: frames decide whose lives count as lives to be mourned. Her *Undoing Gender* (2004) argued that being undone by another is not a failure of the self but a sign of how it is bound to others. The film's men are undone, and their grief is framed as grievable. The couriers of Chapter Three and the domestic workers of Chapter Four fall outside the frame. Sylvia Wynter's "Unsettling the Coloniality of Being/Power/Truth/Freedom" (2003) gives this exclusion its genealogy. "Man," Wynter argued, is a particular, Western-bourgeois genre of the human that overrepresents itself as the human as such, and the task is to move toward the human after Man. The first episode executes a white master, yet its frame keeps the South Asian couriers at the margin. A humanism after Man must include those whom Man's genre casts as its others.

Edward Said's *Humanism and Democratic Criticism* (2004), his last book, defended humanism against its anti-humanist critics by redefining it as critical practice. Drawing on Vico's principle that human beings can know history because they have made it, Said described humanism as worldly, philological, self-critical, and attentive to what a tradition excludes. Dated humanism is humanist in Said's sense: a practice of reading that names its own limits. The film's limits at the couriers and the domestic workers are not refutations of its humanism but the places where that humanism must keep working.

## 6.6 Feminism's Flight, Humanism's Return

Julia Kristeva's "Women's Time" (1979) distinguished two temporalities traditionally associated with female subjectivity — the cyclical, of repetition and rhythm, and the monumental, of an eternity beyond history — from the linear time of history, project, and departure. A first generation of feminism sought women's entry into linear time; a second rejected it for women's time; Kristeva proposed a third attitude that would interiorize the opposition itself. The film distributes these times among its characters. 223's countdown is linear and his ten thousand years monumental; Faye's year is cyclical and her flight a linear project. The date unites them. It is a point on a line, it returns each year as an anniversary, and in the wish for ten thousand years it reaches toward the monumental. Dated humanism is, in Kristeva's terms, a temporality of the third generation.

Luce Irigaray's *An Ethics of Sexual Difference* (1984) called sexual difference the philosophical question of the age. As the passion proper to the encounter of the sexes, she proposed the wonder that Descartes placed first among the pas-

sions, felt before something new before we know whether it is good or bad. Wonder keeps an interval between the two, so that each remains other. The film's opening interval, 0.01 centimetres measured by a policeman's rule, becomes by its end such an interval: the year between counter and sky in which wonder is possible. Descartes, who appeared in Chapter Two as a theorist of tears and sweat, returns here as the theorist of wonder.

Feminist ethics of care completes the account. Carol Gilligan's *In a Different Voice* (1982) and Nel Noddings's *Caring* (1984) described a moral orientation grounded in relationship rather than rule; Eva Feder Kittay's *Love's Labor* (1999) made dependency work a matter of justice. Joan Tronto's *Moral Boundaries* (1993) analysed care into phases — caring about, taking care of, care-giving, and care-receiving — and her *Caring Democracy* (2013) added a fifth, caring with, in which the responsibilities of care are shared and reciprocal. The film's two episodes display care undistributed. 223 cares about without giving care; Faye gives care that is received without being acknowledged. The chiasmus redistributes it. 663, behind the counter, takes up care-giving, and Faye's question in the coda opens a caring with.

Feminism, in this film, is flight: Cixous's *voler*, Nora's departure financed by a wage, the woman who takes the sky. Humanism is return: to the counter, to a shared world, to the other. The film refuses to choose between them, because Faye both flies and returns. Dated humanism is a feminist humanism because the practices it treats as paradigmatically human — waiting, tending, serving, giving time — are those historically assigned to women, and because it demands that they be shared.

## 6.7 Coda: The Film's Own Expiry

The film is itself dated. In 1996 Quentin Tarantino's Rolling Thunder Pictures carried it to North American audiences; in 1998 Kai Tak closed. Wong's later films revisited its figures in a darker key. *In the Mood for Love* (2000) ends at Angkor, where a man whispers a secret into a hollow in a ruined wall and seals it with mud — the can again, memory sealed. *2046* (2004), its title widely read as the last of the fifty years promised in 1984, imagines a train to a place where nothing ever changes and from which no one has returned — the through train again, running toward an unexpiring present. *Chungking Express* remains the film in which the date is given rather than sealed. The 4K restorations of 2020–21, supervised by the director, revised the colour and in places the framing of

his films and provoked debate over whether a released image may be altered: the film itself has been relabelled.

The fifty years promised in 1984 have themselves been dated in ways the film could not foresee. In 2019 mass protests against a bill that would have allowed extradition to mainland China were met by the police with tear gas and rubber bullets, and more than ten thousand people were arrested; some protesters fought the police with bricks and petrol bombs. On 30 June 2020 the Standing Committee of the National People's Congress imposed a national security law on Hong Kong, under which opposition politicians, journalists, and activists have since been prosecuted. Among those charged were the leaders of the Hong Kong Alliance, which had kept the anniversary of 4 June 1989 with a candlelight vigil in Victoria Park every year from 1990 to 2019; the vigil was banned from 2020, at first on public-health grounds, and the Alliance disbanded in 2021. A date the city had kept for thirty years could no longer be kept in public. Britain declared China in breach of the Joint Declaration and in 2021 opened a residence route for holders of British National (Overseas) status, the status it had itself created in 1987 without a right of abode; the pass without a destination discussed in Chapter Five acquired one more than three decades after its creation. Beijing rejects the charge of breach and maintains that "one country, two systems" remains in force.

This thesis has proposed several conceptual instruments: the four data as technologies of time; the *hermeneutics of the label* and the *poetics of relabelling* as the film's two postures toward a dated world; *forensic tenderness* as the affect of the first; the *polychronic image* as the film's formal ground; the *chiasmus of care* as its resolution; and *dated humanism*, in four registers, as its philosophy. It has drawn on overdeterminations that the film does not thematize but that its city and its languages made available: the pineapple of 1967, the *Verfallsdatum*, the sweat that is the heart's fluid, the *Fée* of Perrault's key, and the double sense of 物化 as reification and transformation. Each instrument is offered, like the film's own pass, as a dated thing: provisional, given, and open to rewriting.

The film is now thirty-two years old, and 2047 is twenty-one years away. It has outlived more than half of the interval it could not see past. Its argument survives because it never depended on prediction. It located the human not in knowing the future but in giving it.

Roman letters closed with the formula of their giving: *data*, the place, the day. *Chungking Express* closes in the same way, with a counter, rain, a napkin, and a question about destination. Like a Roman letter, it carries its date: given at Hong Kong, in the year 1994. Dated humanism asks of the human only what the film

asks of its lovers: to mark time, to keep it as long as one can, to give it away, and, when the ink runs, to write again.

# Filmography

*Chungking Express* (重慶森林). Written and directed by Wong Kar-wai. Hong Kong: Jet Tone Production, 1994. Cinematography: Christopher Doyle, Andrew Lau Wai-keung. Editing: William Chang Suk-ping, Hai Kit-wai, Kwong Chi-leung. Art direction: William Chang Suk-ping. Music: Frankie Chan, Roel A. García. Cast: Brigitte Lin Ching-hsia, Takeshi Kaneshiro, Tony Leung Chiu-wai, Faye Wong, Valerie Chow, Piggy Chan. Released in Hong Kong in July 1994; North American release by Rolling Thunder Pictures, 1996; restored 2020–21.
Other films cited, in order of release:

| Year | Film | Director | Principal origin |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1933 | *Queen Christina* | Rouben Mamoulian | United States |
| 1941 | *Two-Faced Woman* | George Cukor | United States |
| 1954 | *Rear Window* | Alfred Hitchcock | United States |
| 1957 | *An Affair to Remember* | Leo McCarey | United States |
| 1958 | *Vertigo* | Alfred Hitchcock | United States |
| 1960 | *Breathless* (*À bout de souffle*) | Jean-Luc Godard | France |
| 1962 | *Cléo from 5 to 7* (*Cléo de 5 à 7*) | Agnès Varda | France |
| 1962 | *L'Eclisse* | Michelangelo Antonioni | Italy |
| 1964 | *Bande à part* | Jean-Luc Godard | France |
| 1964 | *The Umbrellas of Cherbourg* (*Les Parapluies de Cherbourg*) | Jacques Demy | France |
| 1973 | *Outside the Window* (窗外) | Sung Tsun-shou | Taiwan |
| 1974 | *Je tu il elle* | Chantal Akerman | Belgium, France |
| 1975 | *Jeanne Dielman, 23 quai du Commerce, 1080 Bruxelles* | Chantal Akerman | Belgium, France |
| 1978 | *Midnight Express* | Alan Parker | United Kingdom, United States |
| 1980 | *Gloria* | John Cassavetes | United States |
| 1984 | *Love in a Fallen City* (傾城之戀) | Ann Hui | Hong Kong |

| Year | Film | Director | Principal origin |
|---|---|---|---|
| **1986** | *A Better Tomorrow* (英雄本色) | John Woo | Hong Kong |
| **1986** | *Peking Opera Blues* (刀馬旦) | Tsui Hark | Hong Kong |
| **1992** | *Autumn Moon* (秋月) | Clara Law | Hong Kong, Japan |
| **1992** | *Swordsman II* (笑傲江湖之東方不敗) | Ching Siu-tung | Hong Kong |
| **1993** | *The Bride with White Hair* (白髮魔女傳) | Ronny Yu | Hong Kong |
| **1994** | *Ashes of Time* (東邪西毒) | Wong Kar-wai | Hong Kong |
| **1994** | *Vive L'Amour* (愛情萬歲) | Tsai Ming-liang | Taiwan |
| **1995** | *A Chinese Odyssey Part Two: Cinderella* (西遊記大結局之仙履奇緣) | Jeffrey Lau | Hong Kong |
| **1995** | *Fallen Angels* (墮落天使) | Wong Kar-wai | Hong Kong |
| **2000** | *In the Mood for Love* (花樣年華) | Wong Kar-wai | Hong Kong, France |
| **2004** | *2046* | Wong Kar-wai | Hong Kong |

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# Keywords

Wong Kar-wai; *Chungking Express*; Hong Kong cinema; 1997 handover; dated humanism; temporality; expiry; reification (物化); hermeneutics of the label; poetics of relabelling; chiasmus of care; polychronic image; the gift; promise and forgiveness; natality; mourning and melancholia; masquerade; colonial mimicry; tactics and *la perruque*; housework; emotional labour; ethics of care; hospitality and trespass; feminist film theory; postcolonial criticism; star studies; Chinese poetics; boudoir lament (閨怨); swan-maiden tale; Confucian *ren* (仁); Zhuangzi; Lu Xun; Eileen Chang; Hannah Arendt; Jacques Derrida; Hélène Cixous.

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*To mark time, to keep it as long as one can, to give it away, and, when the ink runs, to write again.*

Toward a Dated Humanism
Can, Wig, Key, Pass in Wong Kar-wai's
*Chungking Express*

